

Empowering Local Communities in Disaster Risk Reduction Initiatives

FOREWORD

This document was produced by the [ReadingMachine framework](#). ReadingMachine is designed to generate a high-coverage, structured, traceable mapping of a defined document corpus, organized around a specified set of research questions. The output should be read as a corpus reading, not as an argument, position paper, or normative assessment. The system does not determine what is important, correct, or true. It represents what is present in the corpus under the specified research questions.

The paper is written with each research question handled stand-alone. This allows any reader to pick up and read on any question they are specifically interested in. The cost of this feature is some repetition across sections/research questions.

ReadingMachine operates as a tightly bounded reader. It does not independently determine research questions, define the scope of inquiry, or evaluate the importance or correctness of claims. Reasoning steps—such as the formulation of motivating questions, the definition of the corpus, and the interpretive goals of the analysis—lie with the user. The role of ReadingMachine is to execute a structured reading of the material it is given, according to those externally specified parameters.

For this reason, it is important to state explicitly the research questions that motivated this reading and the process by which the corpus was constructed. These elements define the analytical boundaries within which ReadingMachine operates and, correspondingly, the scope of what this output can be expected to represent.

Readers interested in the underlying methodology, design assumptions, and known trade-offs should consult the accompanying [whitepaper](#).

Research Questions

The research questions guiding this reading were developed by Oxfam through formal research processes, including the development of a Terms of Reference. They are reproduced here for transparency:

1. What disaster risk reduction initiatives have Oxfam, together with its partners and allies, implemented to improve understanding of disaster risk through monitoring or early warning systems for institutions or populations? What role did Oxfam play in these initiatives? What evidence does the corpus provide regarding their effectiveness? What factors enabled, constrained or limited their effectiveness or sustainability?

2. What disaster risk reduction initiatives have Oxfam, together with its partners and allies, implemented to strengthen disaster and/or conflict risk governance by making governance mechanisms more inclusive, stronger and more effective? What role did Oxfam play in these initiatives? What evidence does the corpus provide regarding their effectiveness? What factors enabled, constrained or limited their effectiveness or sustainability?
3. What disaster risk reduction initiatives have Oxfam, together with its partners and allies, implemented to invest in prevention or mitigation measures that build community, social, economic and/or physical resilience and reduce disaster risk? What role did Oxfam play in these initiatives? What evidence does the corpus provide regarding their effectiveness? What factors enabled, constrained or limited their effectiveness or sustainability?
4. What disaster risk reduction initiatives have Oxfam, together with its partners and allies, implemented to strengthen disaster preparedness, recovery and "build back better" efforts so that local institutions and populations are better prepared to respond early to, and recover quickly from, future disasters? What role did Oxfam play in these initiatives? What evidence does the corpus provide regarding their effectiveness? What factors enabled, constrained or limited their effectiveness or sustainability?
5. What disaster risk reduction initiatives have Oxfam, together with its partners and allies, implemented to localize decision-making power, resources and leadership so that disaster risk reduction is increasingly led by local actors, women and other marginalized groups who are disproportionately vulnerable to hazards? What role did Oxfam play in these initiatives? What evidence does the corpus provide regarding their effectiveness? What factors enabled, constrained or limited their effectiveness or sustainability?

Analytical frame

The analytical frame serves as the conceptual lens through which relevance is determined during insight extraction and subsequent synthesis. It does not determine the conclusions of the review, but defines what kinds of claims are considered relevant to the research questions and how structural features are interpreted during corpus reading. The framing is as follows:

Oxfam America is seeking to understand the nature of its contributions to disaster risk reduction over the last 10 years. It is therefore parsing programme reports (i.e. reports that describe, evaluate, or otherwise reflect on disaster risk reduction efforts) to identify the disaster risk reduction initiatives that have been implemented, Oxfam's role in those initiatives, what evidence exists regarding their effectiveness, the factors reported to have influenced their effectiveness or sustainability, and the lessons emerging from their implementation.

An initiative should be understood broadly as a coherent disaster risk reduction intervention, programme, strategy, approach, activity, partnership, governance arrangement, financing mechanism, technological solution, or other organized effort intended to reduce disaster risk or strengthen resilience. Initiatives may comprise multiple components that operate together toward a common objective. The analysis is concerned with these initiatives, Oxfam's role in them, and the evidence reported regarding their implementation and outcomes.

Risk is defined as the likelihood of negative outcomes to human well-being of an event. Risk is determined by the intersection of hazards and vulnerability. A hazard is an event described in terms of its duration, intensity and extent. Vulnerability is the propensity for negative well-being outcomes as a result of exposure to a hazard. Vulnerability is multi-dimensional, determined by, among other variables, to hazard exposure and human capital. Vulnerability is conceived of as structurally determined and historically contingent, produced by intersecting processes of marginalization from both power and resources. Resilience is the inverse of vulnerability, in that it reflects the capacity to withstand a hazard without experiencing deleterious effects to well-being. Like vulnerability is it multidimensional, structural and historically contingent.

Disasters are defined as instances when the scale of the negative impacts of a hazard on well-being exceed the capacity of local institutions to respond.

"Local" institutions and populations are defined as those most immediately impacted by the disaster. They need not be "local" in geographic terms only, as processes such as migration and remittances (for example) can moderate these impacts. There is no clear definition of "a local population/institution". Rather locality is a continuum describing how directly impacted a population or institution is by a disaster. The idea of "populations" is invoked in this analysis to describe collections of people. The language is used to account for the depoliticizing idea of "communities" which assumes higher levels of social cohesiveness. Nonetheless, the literature being parsed, may invoke communities in its description.

Corpus Construction

The corpus underlying this output was generated by an Oxfam led search of internal databases to identify all works with associated disaster risk reduction content. This process was deliberately inclusive so as not to miss any reports. Thus a further step was undertaken whereby the complete reports were sent to an LLM for a one-shot classification to determine whether the report pertained to work done by Oxfam (including work done with partners) on the broad issue of disaster risk reduction. Those documents identified as qualifying were passed to ReadingMachine.

Commented [JM1]: Molly, please describe the exact process here. I can't recall it.

Note that the document sent to the classifier included docx, pdf and ppt file types. Ppt documents were not classified and excluded from the analysis as their prose is not anticipated to suit the chunking strategy of ReadingMachine.

The final corpus contained 71 documents which yielded 13,984 insights. Every document produced at least one insights.

Every part of this paper was generated by the system, save for this foreword and the final reference list.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Oxfam's disaster risk reduction (DRR) initiatives, in collaboration with partners and allies, have focused on empowering local communities through participatory approaches, integrating traditional knowledge with modern systems, and fostering inclusivity and gender equity. Central to these efforts is the establishment of Community Disaster Committees (CDCs) and the implementation of early warning systems (EWS) that combine local wisdom with scientific data. These initiatives have enhanced community preparedness and resilience, particularly in regions like Indonesia, Nepal, and the Philippines, by involving women and youth in leadership roles and decision-making processes.

Oxfam's role has been multifaceted, involving capacity building, technical support, and strategic partnerships with local governments and civil society organizations (CSOs). The organization has facilitated the development of Vulnerability and Risk Assessment (VRA) methodologies and anticipatory action frameworks, which have been crucial in shifting from reactive to proactive disaster management. These efforts have been supported by advocacy for policy and legislative changes, such as the integration of disaster risk reduction into local governance frameworks and the promotion of gender-sensitive strategies.

Despite successes, challenges remain, particularly in areas with limited infrastructure and outdated equipment, which constrain the effectiveness and sustainability of EWS. Financial constraints and socio-economic disparities also pose significant barriers, highlighting the need for improved risk communication strategies and continuous capacity building. Oxfam's initiatives have demonstrated the importance of local ownership and community-driven solutions, although ongoing support and resources are necessary to sustain these efforts.

Oxfam's commitment to gender justice and social inclusion is evident in its initiatives that prioritize women's leadership and the participation of marginalized groups. Projects like the Women Local Humanitarian Leadership (WLHL) Project in Indonesia have fostered networks of women's organizations, promoting women's leadership in disaster risk reduction. These efforts have been instrumental in transforming community dynamics and enhancing resilience by addressing underlying gender-based inequalities.

Overall, Oxfam's disaster risk reduction initiatives have effectively combined participatory approaches with the integration of climate and disaster risk information, leading to improved community preparedness and resilience. The organization's role as a facilitator, advocate, and capacity builder has been crucial in promoting local leadership and sustainable DRR practices, ensuring that initiatives are contextually relevant and effectively address the needs of vulnerable communities.

What disaster risk reduction initiatives have Oxfam, together with its partners and allies, implemented to improve understanding of disaster risk through monitoring or early warning systems for institutions or populations? What role did Oxfam play in these initiatives? What evidence does the corpus provide regarding their effectiveness? What factors enabled, constrained or limited their effectiveness or sustainability?

Question Overview

Oxfam, in collaboration with partners and allies, has implemented a variety of disaster risk reduction initiatives focusing on community-based preparedness and early warning systems (EWS) to enhance understanding and management of disaster risks. These initiatives integrate traditional knowledge with modern technologies, as seen in the establishment of Community Disaster Committees and the use of participatory Vulnerability and Risk Assessment methodologies. Oxfam's role includes facilitating partnerships, providing technical support, and promoting gender-sensitive approaches, which have improved community resilience and inclusivity. Evidence of effectiveness is mixed, with successes in community engagement and resilience-building, but challenges persist due to outdated equipment, limited infrastructure, and the need for improved communication strategies. Factors influencing the sustainability of these initiatives include local capacity, stakeholder involvement, and external constraints such as political instability and climate change.

Community-Based Disaster Preparedness

Oxfam's community-based disaster preparedness initiatives are designed to bolster local capacities through participatory planning and the fusion of traditional knowledge with formal systems (Anguko et al. 2019). A cornerstone of these efforts is the creation of Community Disaster Committees (CDCs) in areas like Bena, Meusin, and Motalun. These committees enhance early warning systems by integrating indigenous wisdom with data from formal sources such as BMKG (Husein et al. 2024; Oxfam n.d._4). CDCs are instrumental in crafting village disaster management plans, which include hazard risk maps and contingency plans, thereby fostering a sense of ownership and responsibility among community members, with a particular focus on women and youth (Ndolu et al. n.d.; Helmi

et al. 2023). Traditional early warning systems, such as the 'Koa' and 'Klalak', enable communities to use natural signs and local communication methods, like shouting and beating electricity poles, to disseminate warnings (Helmi et al. 2022; Mathilde and Team 2021). These traditional systems are augmented by modern technologies and participatory processes, which collectively enhance community preparedness and response capabilities (Helmi et al. 2023).

Oxfam's Vulnerability and Risk Assessment (VRA) methodology underpins these initiatives by engaging stakeholders from community to district levels, ensuring that local challenges are contextualized within broader district priorities (OXFAM-GB et al. 2017; Azhar et al. 2022). This participatory approach is vital for developing a shared understanding of hazards and issues affecting communities, thereby enabling targeted adaptation strategies (Oxfam et al. n.d.; Bolte et al. 2019). The VRA methodology emphasizes the collection of qualitative data and the capture of diverse stakeholder perceptions, as demonstrated in exercises conducted by LEAD Pakistan in Badin District (OXFAM-GB et al. 2017).

Capacity building is a critical component, with community leaders and focal persons of CBOs trained to disseminate and educate their communities on newly adopted cropping calendars and other disaster risk reduction (DRR) practices (Oxfam et al. n.d.; Buisan 2019). Additionally, CSOs design and conduct awareness sessions in target communities through local festivals and community theaters (Oxfam et al. n.d.).

The effectiveness of these initiatives is evident in enhanced community preparedness and resilience, as illustrated by the ACT project, which has successfully integrated women and youth into disaster risk reduction efforts, challenging traditional gender norms and strengthening community cohesion (Ndolu et al. n.d.; Colvin et al. 2018). Nonetheless, challenges persist in ensuring these systems effectively reach and are acted upon by vulnerable groups, underscoring the need for ongoing capacity building and the integration of local knowledge with formal institutional support (Husein et al. 2024; Twigg et al. 2018; Julats Consulting 2021). The I CAN ACT project exemplifies a comprehensive approach to disaster risk reduction by integrating anticipatory action with community-based preparedness, involving multi-stakeholder collaboration, and emphasizing the inclusion of vulnerable groups such as persons with disabilities (Fidiyahfika et al. 2023). Local early warning taskforces, like those led by Sampatiya Devi Khang, play a crucial role in minimizing disaster impacts through awareness and training activities (Oxfam 2019_1).

Oxfam's initiatives across regions, including the Philippines, Solomon Islands, and Vanuatu, under the 'Strengthening Community Preparedness, Rapid Response and Recovery in Asia/Pacific Islands' program, underscore the importance of integrating local market systems and community-based approaches to enhance resilience and preparedness against natural disasters (Barrows 2018). Oxfam's involvement in the greening of the Sahel, supporting farmer-led innovations and policy advocacy, has improved food security and environmental restoration, demonstrating the integration of local knowledge with external

support (Magrath 2020). In Nairobi, a network of community-based volunteers conducts surveillance and operates a dashboard in informal settlements, providing accurate and timely data on hunger and malnutrition, insecurity, and sexual violence (Alcántara n.d.). Community protection structures (CPSs) in the DRC facilitate early warning information sharing and protection analysis, enhancing community self-protection capacities (Oxfam DRC n.d.). In the Sahrawi refugee camps, Oxfam's initiatives like the hydroponics system and small-scale farming have transitioned from traditional aid to resilience-building activities, improving food security and self-sufficiency (Ouchene et al. 2018).

In Nepal, community consultations and the development of early warning systems have been pivotal in disaster risk reduction, with indigenous communities using nature's signals to forecast potential dangers (Alliance for Research and Development Service 2023; Khadka et al. n.d.). Collaboration with religious institutions in forming CDCs has been strategic in leveraging existing community structures and volunteerism, thereby enhancing the effectiveness and sustainability of disaster risk reduction efforts by integrating local cultural and social dynamics (Ndolu et al. n.d.; Oxfam 2023_1).

Overall, Oxfam's initiatives have effectively combined participatory approaches with the integration of climate and disaster risk information, leading to improved community preparedness and resilience, particularly in rapid-onset disasters across multiple regions such as Pakistan, Vanuatu, and the Philippines (Oxfam 2018_2; Lain et al. 2016).

Early Warning Systems and Monitoring

Oxfam, in collaboration with its partners, has developed a comprehensive array of early warning systems (EWS) and monitoring initiatives aimed at enhancing disaster risk understanding and response capabilities. These initiatives are characterized by the integration of modern technologies with traditional knowledge, thereby improving community preparedness and resilience across various geographical contexts. In Nepal, for instance, Oxfam has established community-based EWS that blend scientific data with indigenous practices, facilitating a robust disaster response framework (Alliance for Research and Development Service 2023; Oxfam 2021_1). Similarly, in Pakistan, Oxfam's collaboration with local foundations has led to the creation of automated monitoring systems, which significantly bolstered early action capabilities during the 2010 floods (Oxfam 2018_2; Oxfam Australia 2018). However, challenges such as outdated weather forecasting equipment in regions like Badin underscore the necessity for technological upgrades (OXFAM-GB et al. 2017).

In Indonesia, the ACT project has been pivotal in developing both traditional and modern EWS, merging local wisdom with formal systems to ensure community engagement through simulations and training (Helmi et al. 2023; Husein et al. 2024). This dual approach is particularly effective in areas with limited infrastructure, where traditional methods like 'Koa' and 'Klalak' are employed alongside modern tools to disseminate disaster warnings efficiently (Helmi et al. 2022). The installation of ombrometers for rainfall monitoring

further exemplifies the integration of local and scientific knowledge, enhancing disaster risk comprehension (Fidiyahfika et al. 2023).

Oxfam's initiatives also emphasize capacity building for local governments and communities, as demonstrated in projects across Nepal and the Philippines, where training and contingency plan development are prioritized (Oxfam 2021_1; Oxfam 2018_2). These efforts are bolstered by the establishment of Community Disaster Committees (CDCs) and the incorporation of gender-responsive strategies to ensure inclusivity and effectiveness (Husein et al. 2024; Oxfam 2023_1). In the Philippines, collaboration with local governments has resulted in the installation of automated weather stations, enhancing the reliability of weather forecasts and the dissemination of early warnings (Oxfam 2018_2).

Despite these advancements, challenges persist, particularly in regions with geographical and infrastructural limitations that hinder the effectiveness and sustainability of EWS (Mathilde and Team 2021; Helmi et al. 2022). There is a clear need for improved risk communication strategies and capacity building, alongside fostering local ownership and participation to bolster the resilience of vulnerable communities (Oxfam 2020; Alliance for Research and Development Service 2023). In areas like Flores Timur and Lembata, limited access to climate information and early warning systems highlights the necessity for better dissemination and integration of climate data into local governance (Perdinan et al. 2019).

Oxfam's role in these initiatives often involves facilitating partnerships and providing technical support, as evidenced in the Democratic Republic of Congo, where early warning mechanisms have been implemented to enhance community protection efforts (Oxfam DRC n.d.). The effectiveness of these mechanisms is contingent upon the participatory selection of focal points and the establishment of communication protocols, which are essential for maintaining trust and ensuring the confidentiality of shared information (Oxfam DRC n.d.). In Southeast Asia, Oxfam's GRAISEA program has utilized Vulnerability Risk Assessment tools to improve disaster risk understanding among farmers, thereby enhancing climate resilience and market access (Oxfam 2018_1).

Oxfam's Role and Partnerships

Oxfam's involvement in disaster risk reduction initiatives is characterized by its strategic facilitation of partnerships, provision of technical support, and active community engagement, all aimed at enhancing the understanding and management of disaster risks. Across regions such as Pakistan, the Philippines, Nepal, and Kenya, Oxfam has played a pivotal role in establishing and supporting Early Warning Systems (EWS) through collaborations with local governments, NGOs, and community-based organizations (Oxfam 2018_2; Alliance for Research and Development Service 2023; Oxfam 2023_2; Alcántara n.d.). These partnerships have successfully integrated scientific and indigenous knowledge, thereby improving the effectiveness and sustainability of EWS (Alliance for Research and Development Service 2023; Oxfam 2018_2).

Oxfam's initiatives frequently involve capacity building and technical support, such as the provision of mobile devices for data collection and ensuring data protection, which are essential for effective disaster risk reduction (Barrows 2018; Khadka et al. n.d.; Anguko et al. 2019; Bolte et al. 2019). Acting as a 'knowledge broker,' Oxfam facilitates the dissemination and interpretation of climate and disaster risk information, ensuring it is actionable for local communities (Oxfam 2018_2; Oxfam 2020). The organization's Vulnerability and Risk Assessment (VRA) methodology, which engages stakeholders from community to district levels, exemplifies its commitment to contextualizing challenges and aligning them with district priorities (OXFAM-GB et al. 2017).

The effectiveness of these initiatives is further bolstered by Oxfam's emphasis on multi-stakeholder collaboration, which involves engaging local civil society organizations and leveraging their capacities to establish locally relevant and inclusive resilience strategies (Oxfam 2018_3; Oxfam 2020; Buisan 2019). This approach has proven particularly successful in regions like Pakistan and Timor-Leste, where local empowerment and gender-focused initiatives have been integrated into broader disaster risk reduction strategies (Azhar et al. 2022; Oxfam 2024). Oxfam's role in fostering partnerships with government agencies and local communities has been crucial in implementing effective early warning systems and climate adaptation strategies, as evidenced by collaborations in Uganda, Burkina Faso, and Ethiopia (Twigg et al. 2018; Colvin et al. 2018).

Oxfam's initiatives have led to the creation of multi-stakeholder platforms that facilitate dialogue and collaboration on climate change and disaster risk reduction (DRR), enabling local governments, in partnership with CSOs and CBOs, to identify and address numerous climate-related advocacy issues (Oxfam 2023_2; Dalabajan et al. 2019). The organization has also been involved in innovative projects like the I CAN ACT project in Indonesia, which focuses on anticipatory action to enhance community resilience against climate-related disasters (Fidiyahfika et al. 2023; Helmi et al. 2022; Helmi et al. 2023).

Despite these successes, challenges persist, particularly in the need for improved risk communication strategies and capacity building to ensure the sustainability of these systems (Husein et al. 2024). Oxfam's commitment to localization and equitable partnerships is vital for addressing these challenges, as it empowers local actors and promotes mutual accountability, thereby enhancing the overall effectiveness of disaster risk reduction initiatives (Oxfam n.d._1; Oxfam 2020; Hillier 2018). Regular check-ins and streamlined reporting between Oxfam and local partners, as demonstrated in the Uganda LL-ERF consortium, exemplify Oxfam's efforts to maintain effective communication and coordination (Manlutac et al. 2024).

Effectiveness and Sustainability

The effectiveness and sustainability of Oxfam's disaster risk reduction initiatives are intricately linked to the integration of early warning systems (EWS) and active community engagement. Tools such as the Household Economy Approach (HEA) and Pre-Crisis Market

Analysis (PCMA) have been instrumental in enhancing disaster preparedness and resilience by offering detailed insights into livelihoods and market systems (Barrows 2018; Oxfam 2021_1; Oxfam n.d._6). However, the efficacy of these systems is often hampered by outdated equipment and limited infrastructure, particularly in remote areas like Badin and certain Indonesian villages, where geographical challenges and resource constraints impede the development of systematic EWS (OXFAM-GB et al. 2017; Mathilde and Team 2021; Helmi et al. 2023).

Community-based EWS have proven effective in disseminating disaster warnings, yet their success hinges on local capacity and infrastructure, which are frequently inadequate (Helmi et al. 2022; Husein et al. 2024). The involvement of local stakeholders and the integration of indigenous knowledge are crucial for the sustainability of these initiatives, as demonstrated by projects that promote local ownership and participation (Julats Consulting 2021; Oxfam 2024). Nonetheless, challenges such as limited technical capacity, insufficient funding, and the need for improved communication strategies persist, affecting the long-term viability of these systems (Mukute 2023; Oxfam DRC n.d.; Mathilde and Team 2021).

Oxfam's role in these initiatives is multifaceted, encompassing capacity building, partnership development, and technical support, which collectively enhance the effectiveness of disaster risk reduction efforts (Manlutac et al. 2024; Khadka et al. n.d.). The integration of financial inclusion strategies, including insurance and cash transfers, further bolsters resilience by addressing economic vulnerabilities (Hillier 2018; Dalabajan et al. 2019). However, the sustainability of these initiatives is often constrained by external factors such as political instability, market disruptions, and climate change, necessitating ongoing adaptation and support (Van Hemelrijck 2020; Oxfam n.d._5).

The ACT project in Indonesia has made significant strides in achieving its primary outcomes and establishing a foundation for phase 2, although existing early warning systems require enhancement, particularly for vulnerable groups (Husein et al. 2024). The project focuses on assessing the effectiveness of current EWS and the capacity of communities to utilize them for timely disaster preparedness, emphasizing improved communication strategies, accessibility for people with disabilities, and community preparedness drills (Husein et al. 2024). Despite the lack of systematic end-to-end EWS in some target villages, traditional methods and communication channels like phone calls and social media are employed to disseminate disaster information, underscoring a reliance on informal systems due to infrastructural limitations (Mathilde and Team 2021).

The effectiveness of Oxfam's initiatives in enhancing disaster risk understanding is evidenced by the active participation of local stakeholders in policy development processes, such as the Local Disaster and Climate Resilience Plan (LDCRP), and the dissemination of climate change information through trusted sources like I/NGOs and local government (Khadka et al. n.d.; Oxfam 2023_2). Factors enabling the effectiveness of these initiatives include participatory approaches and the involvement of local stakeholders in policy

development, while constraints include limited awareness of multi-stakeholder platforms and climate-smart technologies among the local population (Khadka et al. n.d.).

The effectiveness of early warning mechanisms is influenced by the participatory selection of focal points and the establishment of communication protocols, which are essential for maintaining trust and ensuring the confidentiality and neutrality of shared information (Oxfam DRC n.d.). The sustainability and appropriateness of early warning mechanisms depend on thorough risk analyses and the mitigation of potential risks, such as the perception of focal points as informants and the dangers associated with providing them with material resources (Oxfam DRC n.d.).

Gender and Social Inclusion

Oxfam's disaster risk reduction initiatives are deeply rooted in gender-sensitive approaches and the inclusion of vulnerable groups, particularly women and people with disabilities, within disaster risk management frameworks (Oxfam 2023_1). These initiatives are characterized by the integration of gender-responsive strategies into early warning systems, ensuring both inclusivity and effectiveness (Alliance for Research and Development Service 2023; Oxfam 2019_1). Oxfam's advocacy efforts have successfully led to the adoption of government-led weather forecasting models that are specifically designed to reach rural women and men, thereby enhancing the accessibility of critical information (Oxfam 2017). The incorporation of feminist principles and gender considerations has been pivotal in prioritizing women in interventions, which in turn enhances the effectiveness and sustainability of these initiatives (Azhar et al. 2022; Oxfam 2020; Anguko et al. 2019).

Collaboration with local partners has been instrumental for Oxfam in advocating for gender justice and social inclusion, resulting in policy changes and increased representation of marginalized groups in decision-making forums (Oxfam 2019_1; Manlutac et al. 2024). The EMBRACE project, supported by the WE-Care initiative, introduced innovations in care work that reduced the time women spent on unpaid care work, thereby allowing them to engage more in productive activities and community involvement, ultimately improving their social and economic status (Buisan 2019). Initiatives such as the Women Local Humanitarian Leadership (WLHL) Project have fostered networks of women's organizations and humanitarian actors, promoting women's leadership in disaster risk reduction (Fidiyahfika 2023; Oxfam in Indonesia et al. 2023). This project highlights the transformative role of women's self-help groups in fostering financial independence, leadership, and active participation in disaster risk reduction activities (Oxfam 2025_2). These efforts are supported by the creation of collaborative consortia and the development of gender-inclusive policies, although challenges such as gender-unfair social norms and limited organizational capacity persist (Fidiyahfika 2023).

The effectiveness of these initiatives is further evidenced by the integration of gender and power analyses, which tailor interventions to address the specific needs and vulnerabilities

of different groups, thereby enhancing sustainability and impact (Oxfam 2019_1). The CRAFS project, for example, benefited from gender-specific strategies and a focus on off-farm activities, which enhanced women's decision-making power and access to resources within households (Pretari et al. 2019). Community-centered models and public-private-people partnerships have ensured that insurance schemes and other resources are inclusive, addressing the needs of marginalized groups, including women (Hillier 2018). However, factors such as under-budgeting, inadequate human resources, and inequitable participation of women have constrained the effectiveness and sustainability of some projects (Mukute 2023). Overall, Oxfam's gender-sensitive approaches in disaster risk reduction have significantly contributed to improving resilience outcomes by addressing underlying gender-based inequalities and promoting women's leadership and participation in decision-making processes (Oxfam 2019_1; Oxfam 2020). Oxfam's disaster risk reduction initiatives in Türkiye and Syria involved a comprehensive approach that combined immediate emergency response with long-term recovery efforts, focusing on water and sanitation, food security, livelihoods, and protection, while also emphasizing the empowerment of women and local communities (Oxfam 2024).

Oxfam has also played a crucial role in brokering relationships between farmers, small business owners, and financial service providers to support vulnerable households' access to equitable financial services, including savings, loans, and insurance, and the use of prepaid debit cards for disaster relief (Oxfam 2018_3; Husein et al. 2024). The organization has facilitated the development of early warning systems that incorporate both indigenous and scientific knowledge, ensuring that these systems are accessible and comprehensible for all genders (Lain et al. 2018; Alliance for Research and Development Service 2023). In Indonesia, projects like the ICDRC have integrated Climate Smart Disaster Risk Management (CSDRM) and Climate Resilient Sustainable Agriculture and Livelihoods (CRSA/L) frameworks to enhance disaster risk reduction, focusing on increasing adaptive capacity and addressing structural causes of poverty and vulnerability, with a particular emphasis on vulnerable groups like women and children (Oxfam in Indonesia 2019; Perdinan et al. 2019). ACCRA's contribution to the MoA's Fast Track Investments (FTI) was significant in shaping local CRGE planning practices that are adaptive, gender-sensitive, and people-centered (Colvin et al. 2018).

The I CAN ACT project exemplifies a comprehensive approach to disaster risk reduction by integrating anticipatory action with community-based preparedness, involving multi-stakeholder collaboration, and emphasizing the inclusion of vulnerable groups such as persons with disabilities, which collectively enhance the understanding and management of disaster risks in flood-prone areas (Fidiyahfika et al. 2023; Helmi et al. 2023). The sustainability of these initiatives is influenced by factors such as community engagement, the integration of gender justice and inclusiveness, and the ability to leverage local resources and partnerships for ongoing support and capacity building (Resilience Development Initiative 2021_1). Factors that enabled the effectiveness of the ERF initiative include the consortium approach, which fostered collaboration and mutual support among

local partners, and the focus on women leadership (Progress Inc. 2023). Indicators specifically addressing issues of protection, gender, equity, and accountability in the presence of local actors, beneficiaries, and decision-makers are crucial for the success of these initiatives (Oxfam 2021_1).

Conflict

The theme of conflict in the effectiveness and sustainability of Oxfam's disaster risk reduction initiatives is underscored by divergent interpretations and assessments, particularly concerning the Early Warning System (EWS) indicator within the MACP project. The absence of a precise definition for this indicator has led to varying interpretations between the Oxfam team and the consultation team, resulting in inconsistent understandings of project objectives and outcomes (Mathilde and Team 2021). This ambiguity complicates the evaluation of the initiatives' success.

Impact studies and evaluations reveal practical challenges and limitations in the implementation of EWS. In Thailand, an impact study indicated negligible differences in the use of climate information between participating households and control groups, suggesting limited effectiveness of the initiatives (Oxfam 2018_2). Similarly, a review of early action noted a delayed organizational recognition of El Niño's impact by Oxfam, which affected the timeliness of responses (Oxfam 2018_2).

Further evaluations in other regions expose structural and operational deficiencies. Many early-warning committees are not effectively integrated with state technical services, limiting their capacity to disseminate useful information to communities (Fuller et al. 2018). A significant portion of respondents in project communities were unaware of the existence of early-warning committees, and only a minority utilized weather forecasting information in their agricultural practices. Specifically, only 21 percent of farming households in the Centre-North and 15 percent in the North made use of such information (Fuller et al. 2018).

In Indonesia, the absence of a formal early warning system and reliance on public reports for disaster response highlight systemic gaps in information dissemination and utilization. The lack of online platforms for climate information further restricts the reach and impact of these initiatives (Oxfam in Indonesia 2019). Additionally, there is a noted deficiency in the dissemination and utilization of climate information for disaster management (Oxfam in Indonesia 2019).

Technological constraints are also evident in the VRA exercise in Badin District, where outdated equipment severely hampers the effectiveness of early warning systems, indicating a critical need for technological upgrades (OXFAM-GB et al. 2017). These conflicting perspectives underscore the complex challenges in achieving effective and sustainable disaster risk reduction through early warning systems.

What disaster risk reduction initiatives have Oxfam, together with its partners and allies, implemented to strengthen disaster and/or conflict risk governance by making governance mechanisms more inclusive, stronger and more effective? What role did Oxfam play in these initiatives? What evidence does the corpus provide regarding their effectiveness? What factors enabled, constrained or limited their effectiveness or sustainability?

Question Overview

Oxfam, in collaboration with its partners, has implemented a range of disaster risk reduction initiatives aimed at strengthening governance mechanisms to be more inclusive, effective, and sustainable. These initiatives are organized around five key themes: policy and legislative advocacy, community empowerment and participation, multi-stakeholder collaboration, inclusivity and gender empowerment, and capacity building and institutional strengthening. Oxfam's role has been pivotal in advocating for policy changes, fostering community-based governance models, facilitating multi-stakeholder partnerships, and promoting gender-inclusive leadership. Evidence of effectiveness includes enhanced community resilience, improved governance processes, and increased participation of marginalized groups. However, challenges such as political, financial, and institutional barriers, as well as cultural constraints, continue to limit the full potential and sustainability of these initiatives. Addressing these challenges requires enhanced coordination, increased funding, and a focus on inclusive governance mechanisms.

Policy and Legislative Advocacy

Oxfam, in collaboration with its partners, has played a pivotal role in advocating for policy and legislative reforms to embed disaster risk reduction (DRR) within governance frameworks, thereby fostering sustainable practices. A significant aspect of this advocacy has been the support provided to local governments in crafting and executing Local Disaster and Climate Resilience Plans (LDCRP), which have been crucial in integrating climate and disaster resilience into local governance structures (Oxfam 2023_2; Khadka et al. n.d.; Colvin et al. 2018). These initiatives have heightened awareness and participation among local communities, with civil society organizations (CSOs) and community-based organizations (CBOs) actively engaging in policy development processes (Oxfam 2023_2; Oxfam et al. n.d.; Bolte et al. 2019; COSACA 2019).

Oxfam's advocacy efforts have also extended to national policy influence, as demonstrated by the successful enactment of the Nepal Disaster Management Bill and the amendment of the Brick Control Act in Bangladesh, which curbed unsustainable practices and encouraged alternative technologies (Oxfam 2018_3; Van Hemelrijck 2020). In the Philippines, Oxfam's provision of advocacy and media training, along with regional support, facilitated the

lobbying for a 'People's Survival Fund', culminating in legislation for a AUD \$26.4 million fund dedicated to community-level resilience activities (Oxfam Australia 2018). In Bangladesh, the PSBiB project was instrumental in policy changes addressing topsoil extraction and promoting sustainable building materials (Van Hemelrijck 2020). The CPACC project empowered local advocacy by informing community members about national government funds allocated to the District Council (Lain et al. 2018). These legislative advancements underscore the effectiveness of strategic lobbying and alliance-building in overcoming political obstacles and vested interests. The IUWGA project in Pakistan has operated within the framework of recent local government reforms (Van Hemelrijck 2019). In Niger, the decentralization of powers to local communities and institutions formed part of an anti-desertification strategy, illustrating the impact of governance reforms on environmental policy (Magrath 2020).

In Indonesia, Oxfam's support for local women's rights organizations has resulted in the gender mainstreaming of disaster risk management, with gender considerations reflected in sub-national development plans (Oxfam 2019_1). Village-level policy advocacy, incorporating a GEDSI perspective, has focused on empowering local actors and allocating program budgets for village preparedness (Oxfam in Indonesia et al. 2023). Advocacy with local authorities has been crucial in securing women's access to social and economic rights (Oxfam 2019_2). Efforts to advocate for village regulations on gender in humanitarian programs through Musrenbangdesa (village meetings) have been part of these initiatives (Fidiyahfika 2023). Similarly, in Vanuatu, Oxfam's advocacy has ensured women's representation in national climate change and DRR policy discussions (Oxfam 2019_1). Oxfam and its partners have successfully advocated for the deployment of Women Development Officers in response operations and the integration of gender minimum standards in national humanitarian policy and response plans (Oxfam 2017). The GRAISEA program's incorporation of human rights and gender transformation into its systems change approach has influenced ASEAN policies, contributing to long-term sustainability and resilience in disaster risk governance (Oxfam 2018_1).

The effectiveness of these initiatives is further evidenced by the integration of DRR into local governance structures, as demonstrated by the ICDRC project's facilitation of regional action plans and local regulations (Wimbardana et al. 2023; Helmi et al. 2022; Helmi et al. 2023). In Nepal, the Constitution now emphasizes disaster management, assigning preparedness, rescue, relief, and rehabilitation as shared responsibilities between federal and provincial governments, while local governments are exclusively tasked with disaster management (Alliance for Research and Development Service 2023). Nepal's constitutional and legal framework robustly supports social protection, with rights to social security, employment, education, health, food, and housing enshrined in the Constitution (Ojha n.d.). DRR plans at the village level have been integrated into the RPJMKec of each sub-district and the RPJMD of TTS district (Mathilde and Team 2021). However, challenges persist, including policy gaps, limited government and community capacity, and the need for stronger partnerships (Oxfam in Indonesia 2019). In Zomba City, the implementation of by-

laws and legally binding policies, supported by central government departments and other organizations, is crucial for sustainable development (Julats Consulting 2021).

Oxfam's initiatives in disaster risk reduction emphasize the integration of risk reduction and risk finance, advocating for comprehensive strategies that combine insurance with other measures like social protection to enhance resilience (Hillier 2018). In Syria, Oxfam joined collective advocacy efforts, co-drafting letters to the Syria Donor Working Group to support funding post-earthquake (Oxfam 2024). In El Salvador, the recent approval of the National Policy for Civil Protection, Risk Prevention and Disaster Mitigation marked a significant advancement in disaster preparedness and response capacity (Oxfam 2020). In the Philippines, advocacy and media training contributed to the passage of legislation for the People's Survival Fund, supporting community-level resilience activities (Oxfam 2018_3). Republic Act No. 10121, or the Philippine Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Act, provided a comprehensive, all-hazard, multisectoral, interagency, and community-based approach to disaster risk management (Oxfam 2023_1). The municipal government leads all policy decisions in disaster risk reduction initiatives (Oxfam 2021_1). The formation of CDCs was endorsed by a Village Head Decree, providing legal legitimacy and enabling access to Village Funds (Ndolu et al. n.d.).

Overall, Oxfam's policy and legislative advocacy has significantly bolstered disaster risk governance by promoting inclusive, sustainable, and effective governance mechanisms. Oxfam's interventions, aimed at enabling policy shifts, have the potential to transform institutional frameworks fundamentally (Twigg et al. 2018). The establishment of the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) under the National Disaster Management Act underscores the government's commitment to a holistic, inclusive, and integrated approach (Oxfam n.d._3). Oxfam's role in resilience governance includes urging governments to transition from rhetoric to action in implementing good governance (Oxfam n.d._1). Oxfam's policy advocacy has been crucial in achieving significant policy changes across multiple countries, such as the adoption of new decrees in Laos and the establishment of MoUs in Zambia and Uganda (Oxfam Novib 2021). An advocacy strategy should be prioritized to work with local development structures (LDS) to agree on a common governance approach (Oxfam International 2018). Oxfam ensures that all policy and political processes it engages in are directed towards eradicating poverty, inequality, and gender-based inequality (Oxfam 2021_2). The project aligns with SADC and national DRM policies, aiming to address the root causes of vulnerability and promote sustainable development (Mukute 2023). These efforts have not only enhanced community resilience but also influenced national and regional policy landscapes, demonstrating the transformative potential of strategic advocacy in disaster risk reduction.

Community Empowerment and Participation

Oxfam, alongside its partners, has made substantial strides in enhancing community empowerment and participation within disaster risk governance frameworks. This has been achieved through the establishment and support of community-based organizations (CBOs)

and participatory governance models, which have collectively fostered inclusive decision-making processes, strengthened local governance, and bolstered community resilience. In Bangladesh, Vanuatu, and Sri Lanka, Oxfam's initiatives have facilitated community input in response planning, thereby improving trust and collaboration between communities and governance structures (Manlutac et al. 2024; Oxfam 2018_3; Lain et al. 2016).

Central to these efforts is the participatory approach, exemplified by the Community-Managed Disaster Risk Reduction (CMDRR) strategy in Kenya and the formation of Community Disaster Committees (CDCs) in Indonesia and the Philippines. These initiatives empower local communities, particularly women and youth, to assume leadership roles in disaster preparedness and response, thereby increasing community engagement in disaster planning and integrating local plans into broader governance structures (Husein et al. 2024; Helmi et al. 2023; Lain et al. 2016; Oxfam 2023_2).

Oxfam's projects have also underscored the importance of fostering relationships between communities and local governments. For instance, the IUWGA project in Pakistan organized communities into Effective Citizen Groups (ECGs) to influence local governance and improve WASH services, leading to enhanced accountability and responsiveness from local authorities (Van Hemelrijck 2019; Oxfam 2023_1).

In the Rautahat and Saptari districts, the "Enhancing CSOs Roles as Key Development Partners for Climate Resilient Policies and Practices in Province-2" project mobilized over 134 CSOs and CBOs, creating a conducive environment for collaboration and knowledge sharing on climate change. This initiative resulted in significant participation in local planning processes, with 73.7% of CSO and CBO members acknowledging a supportive local government environment for raising climate issues, and 90.8% reporting effective engagement in planning and decision-making (Oxfam 2023_2).

In Ethiopia, the ACCRA initiative supported a decentralized and participatory approach to disaster risk governance, integrating local knowledge with scientific evidence to enhance community adaptive capacity. This approach was scaled up to cover multiple woredas, demonstrating the benefits of improved departmental collaboration and participatory planning (Colvin et al. 2018).

Overall, these initiatives have proven effective in increasing community participation in governance processes, enhancing local capacities, and fostering sustainable partnerships between communities and government entities. Nonetheless, challenges persist in ensuring the sustainability of these efforts, particularly in maintaining community engagement and securing ongoing support from local authorities (Oxfam 2025_2; Oxfam 2020).

Multi-Stakeholder Collaboration

Oxfam's disaster risk reduction initiatives highlight the critical role of multi-stakeholder collaboration in enhancing disaster risk governance. These initiatives engage a diverse

array of actors, including governments, non-governmental organizations (NGOs), civil society organizations (CSOs), and the private sector, to cultivate governance mechanisms that are inclusive, effective, and sustainable. Oxfam functions as a convener, facilitator, and broker, ensuring that partnerships are anchored in shared objectives and mutual accountability (Oxfam 2023_2; Oxfam 2021_2; Van Hemelrijck 2020).

The effectiveness of these collaborations is evident across various contexts. In Nepal, Oxfam's collaboration with local governments and CSOs resulted in the creation of Local Disaster and Climate Resilience Plans (LDCRPs), which have strengthened local governance and policy development (Oxfam 2023_2). Similarly, in Ethiopia, the ACCRA program facilitated systemic governance changes by bridging gaps between ministries and sectors, thereby promoting adaptive capacity and climate resilience (Colvin et al. 2018). In Pakistan, the Local Adaptation Plan of Action (LAPA) involved participatory processes with community members, local NGOs, and government officials, thereby reinforcing local disaster risk governance (Oxfam et al. n.d.).

Oxfam's initiatives often integrate local knowledge and resources, fostering inclusive governance and enhancing advocacy capacity. For example, the SEA project in Indonesia incorporated Locally Led Adaptation principles into municipal governance, ensuring that climate adaptation strategies are both locally driven and scientifically informed (Oxfam et al. 2024). In Vanuatu, Oxfam supported the establishment of the Vanuatu Climate Action Network, which enhanced collaboration between international and national civil society actors (Oxfam 2018_3).

Despite challenges such as the need for sustained engagement and balancing power dynamics among stakeholders, strategic partnerships like those in the SEA project demonstrate the potential for transformative change by embedding Locally Led Adaptation principles into municipal governance (Oxfam et al. 2024). In Ethiopia, ACCRA's role as a 'trusted adviser' embedded in core ministries underscores the importance of long-term relationships and technical competence in fostering systemic change (Colvin et al. 2018).

Oxfam's multi-stakeholder partnerships are pivotal in achieving resilient development outcomes by leveraging local knowledge, fostering inclusive governance, and enhancing advocacy capacity, thereby contributing to more effective and sustainable disaster risk reduction initiatives (Oxfam 2018_3; Twigg et al. 2018). The integration of gender justice and the empowerment of local communities, particularly women, are central to these efforts, as evidenced by initiatives like the WLHL Project in Indonesia, which focuses on women's leadership in disaster resilience (Oxfam in Indonesia et al. 2023).

Overall, Oxfam's approach to disaster risk reduction through multi-stakeholder collaboration emphasizes the integration of risk reduction and risk finance, advocating for comprehensive strategies that combine insurance with other measures like social protection to enhance resilience (Hillier 2018). This approach necessitates balancing short-

term emergency responses with long-term social change processes, emphasizing local leadership and inclusive governance to ensure sustainable and effective outcomes (Oxfam 2021_2).

Inclusivity and Gender Empowerment

Oxfam's disaster risk reduction initiatives have markedly advanced inclusivity and gender empowerment within governance frameworks by embedding gender considerations and empowering marginalized groups, particularly women and youth. This strategic integration has transformed perceptions of women from mere aid recipients to leaders, thereby enhancing the quality and inclusivity of response strategies (Manlutac et al. 2024). Such transformations are evident in contexts like Vanuatu and the Solomon Islands, where women have assumed leadership roles within community organizations, leading to increased respect for women's perspectives and a shift in gender norms (Oxfam 2019_1). Oxfam's feminist approach has been instrumental in promoting gender-inclusive leadership, as demonstrated by the Women Local Humanitarian Leadership (WLHL) Project in Indonesia. This project has fostered a network of women's organizations and humanitarian actors, promoting women's leadership in disaster risk governance (Fidiyahfika 2023). The network facilitates the exchange of best practices and strategies, resulting in evidence-based models and policy advocacy efforts that integrate gender equality, disability, and social inclusion into disaster management programs (Oxfam in Indonesia et al. 2023).

The establishment of Community Disaster Committees (CDCs) in villages such as Motalun exemplifies the effectiveness of inclusive governance. These committees, characterized by significant female leadership, have empowered women and youth, altering leadership dynamics and enhancing community engagement in disaster risk reduction efforts (Husein et al. 2024). Nonetheless, challenges persist, as cultural factors and entrenched gender norms can hinder the participation and empowerment of women and marginalized groups in decision-making processes (Mathilde and Team 2021). Oxfam's initiatives have also underscored the importance of local leadership and community participation in governance, as evidenced in Nepal, where local government decision-making has become more inclusive and responsive, with increased participation from women, people with disabilities, and marginalized groups (Oxfam 2023_2). These efforts underscore the critical role of inclusive governance in enhancing the effectiveness and sustainability of disaster risk reduction initiatives.

In Nepal, local leadership of disaster funds has enabled recipients to implement rapid, high-quality, diverse, and gender-sensitive responses, with 69.2% of CSO members perceiving local government decision-making as inclusive and responsive, a significant rise from the baseline value of 6% (Oxfam 2023_2). Local governments have conducted programs such as 'Mayor with Community', 'public auditing', and 'social auditing' to ensure decision-making is inclusive and responsive, achieving a target of 75% improvement in decision-making based on inclusion, accountability, and participation (Oxfam 2023_2). These initiatives encourage local government processes to be inclusive, accountable, and participatory,

involving community members including women, people with disabilities, Dalit, marginalized groups, and hard-to-reach populations (Oxfam 2023_2).

Oxfam's role in strengthening disaster and conflict risk governance includes collaboration with local partners and authorities to enhance water and sanitation infrastructure, support women's cooperatives, and advocate for policy changes, demonstrating a commitment to inclusive governance and sustainable recovery (Oxfam 2024). The partnership approach adopted was feminist, with Oxfam enhancing participation and power sharing with partners throughout the response, contributing to a more inclusive response by targeting programs towards women and considering diverse needs (Azhar et al. 2022). Initiatives in collaboration with CIS Timor, such as the ACT project, focus on strengthening disaster risk governance by enhancing community capacity in disaster response, advocating for disaster response financing, and promoting transformational leadership among women and youth, which are crucial for inclusive and effective governance mechanisms (Oxfam n.d._4).

Capacity Building and Institutional Strengthening

Oxfam's initiatives in capacity building and institutional strengthening have markedly advanced disaster risk governance by empowering local governments, civil society organizations (CSOs), and community-based organizations (CBOs) to manage disaster risks more effectively. Central to these efforts is the development of governance systems and operational frameworks, exemplified by the LL-ERF consortia's creation of governance manuals and standards, which build on previous projects like ELNHA (Manlutac et al. 2024). Oxfam's adaptable role as a consultant, trainer, and network broker has been crucial in meeting diverse community needs, facilitating partnership mapping, and enhancing local consortia's capacity to manage humanitarian responses (Manlutac et al. 2024). The consortia organized webinars, field visits, and experience-sharing sessions to bolster collective capacity and mechanisms for locally led humanitarian response, with local grant managers playing a key role in enhancing the impact and conflict resolution capabilities of humanitarian efforts (Manlutac et al. 2024).

In Nepal, Oxfam's collaboration with over 134 CSOs and CBOs has significantly improved their capacity in climate change and disaster risk reduction (DRR), leading to increased participation in policy formulation and enhanced decision-making processes grounded in inclusion and accountability (Oxfam 2023_2; Alliance for Research and Development Service 2023). The project provided training and orientation on climate change and DRR, enabling participants to effectively articulate and raise issues within their local government. Notably, 105 trained CSO members have actively participated in DRR and climate-smart policy/programme formulation processes (Oxfam 2023_2). The project also fortified local disaster management committees, which now advocate for budget allocations to disaster management funds, reflecting increased local government ownership and capacity (Oxfam 2023_2).

In Pakistan, initiatives such as the IUWGA project have enhanced urban WASH governance

by establishing social accountability mechanisms and improving local government responsiveness to community needs (Van Hemelrijck 2019; Azhar et al. 2022). This project demonstrated the effectiveness of participatory governance models in improving WASH delivery and reducing water-borne diseases, with notable improvements in community relationships and local government responsiveness (Van Hemelrijck 2019). Similarly, in Ethiopia, the ACCRA project has integrated adaptive capacity frameworks into DRR governance, supporting a decentralized and participatory approach that strengthens local adaptive capacities (Colvin et al. 2018; Helmi et al. 2022).

The effectiveness of these initiatives is evidenced by increased community engagement, improved governance processes, and enhanced institutional capacities across various regions. However, challenges remain in fully integrating gender equality and inclusivity in decision-making processes, underscoring the need for continued focus on these areas (Resilience Development Initiative 2021_2; Fidiyahfika 2023). Oxfam's role as a knowledge broker and facilitator of partnerships has been pivotal in ensuring the sustainability and scalability of these initiatives, as demonstrated by the successful integration of community resilience priorities into national and sub-national planning (Oxfam Australia 2018; COSACA 2019). Oxfam's approach includes addressing the root causes of injustice, poverty, and inequality, and focusing on drivers of risks, shocks, and uncertainty in fragile, complex, and conflict-affected contexts (Oxfam 2021_2; Mukute 2023).

Challenges and Constraints

Disaster risk reduction (DRR) initiatives encounter significant challenges and constraints, primarily stemming from political, financial, and institutional barriers. Political interests frequently obstruct the equitable distribution of resources and the activation of contingency plans, as evidenced in Bangladesh and other regions (Barrows 2018; Van Hemelrijck 2020; OXFAM-GB et al. 2017). Institutional frameworks often prove inadequate, with local governance structures lacking the necessary funding and support to implement effective disaster management strategies (OXFAM-GB et al. 2017; Oxfam n.d._3). The integration of DRR plans into broader governance frameworks is inconsistent, often impeded by jurisdictional uncertainties and a lack of coordination among agencies (Mathilde and Team 2021; Oxfam n.d._3; Oxfam in Indonesia 2019).

Financial constraints further limit the effectiveness of these initiatives (COSACA 2019). Many projects suffer from under-budgeting and increased costs, exacerbated by inflation and complex fund disbursement procedures (Mukute 2023). The absence of dedicated funding for DRR activities at local levels results in insufficient resources to address the needs of vulnerable communities (Helmi et al. 2022; Van Hemelrijck 2019). Additionally, procedural budgeting issues and the lack of clear cash distribution guidelines hinder effective resource allocation (Alliance for Research and Development Service 2023).

Institutional barriers include poor coordination among government agencies and a lack of integration of DRR into development plans (Bolte et al. 2019; Resilience Development

Initiative 2021_1). This is compounded by high staff turnover and entrenched bureaucratic structures that impede effective communication and collaboration (Alcántara n.d.; Twigg et al. 2018; Wimbardana et al. 2023). The absence of clear roles and responsibilities across different governance levels further complicates the implementation of DRR initiatives (Ojha n.d.; Alliance for Research and Development Service 2023). In some regions, such as Malaka district, DRR forums and plans are either non-existent or not integrated into local governance structures (Mathilde and Team 2021).

Cultural and social factors also constrain the effectiveness of DRR initiatives (Fidiyahfika 2023). Gender inequalities and entrenched norms limit women's participation in governance and decision-making processes, affecting the inclusivity and sustainability of these initiatives (Husein et al. 2024; Van Hemelrijck 2019). Additionally, the lack of community engagement and awareness about DRR plans and policies undermines the potential for effective disaster management (Mathilde and Team 2021; Julats Consulting 2021). In some areas, such as TTS district, the lack of coordination and comprehensive contingency plans further limits the effectiveness of existing policies (Mathilde and Team 2021).

Overall, these challenges underscore the need for enhanced coordination, increased funding, and inclusive governance mechanisms to improve the effectiveness and sustainability of disaster risk reduction initiatives (Oxfam 2019_2). There is a pressing need to bolster the capacity of local partners to advocate and influence government policy for sustainable outcomes (Oxfam 2018_3; Oxfam 2020). The integration of systemic learning and policy dialogues through platforms like the MSP is essential to address ongoing challenges and ensure continued stakeholder engagement (Van Hemelrijck 2020).

What disaster risk reduction initiatives have Oxfam, together with its partners and allies, implemented to invest in prevention or mitigation measures that build community, social, economic and/or physical resilience and reduce disaster risk? What role did Oxfam play in these initiatives? What evidence does the corpus provide regarding their effectiveness? What factors enabled, constrained or limited their effectiveness or sustainability?

Question Overview

Oxfam, in collaboration with partners and allies, has implemented a range of disaster risk reduction initiatives focusing on community-based approaches, climate-smart agriculture, gender equity, financial mechanisms, infrastructure development, and conflict resolution. These initiatives aim to build resilience by empowering local communities through

participatory planning, capacity building, and strategic partnerships with local governments. Evidence of effectiveness includes increased local government budget allocations for climate actions and improved food security through sustainable agricultural practices. However, challenges such as financial constraints, cultural norms, and resource allocation conflicts can limit the sustainability and effectiveness of these initiatives. Oxfam's role has been pivotal in facilitating partnerships, providing technical and financial support, and advocating for policy changes to enhance community resilience and sustainability.

Community-Based Disaster Risk Reduction

Oxfam's community-based disaster risk reduction (CBDRR) initiatives are designed to empower local communities through participatory planning, capacity building, and the formation of community disaster committees (CDCs). These efforts integrate disaster risk reduction (DRR) strategies into community structures, thereby enhancing local governance and stakeholder engagement (Manlutac et al. 2024; Oxfam 2023_2; Husein et al. 2024). Strategic partnerships with local government units provide essential policy support, technical assistance, and resources, exemplified by projects like EMBRACE in the Philippines (Buisan 2019). Oxfam also facilitates consortia such as the Mahideb Jubo Somaj Kallayan Somity (MJSKS) in Bangladesh and the Western Uganda Humanitarian Platform (WUHP) in Uganda, which leverage local resources and networks to scale up responses (Manlutac et al. 2024). The effectiveness of these initiatives is demonstrated by increased local government budget allocations for climate actions and the development of local policies and adaptation plans, supported by multi-stakeholder collaboration (Oxfam 2023_2; Oxfam et al. n.d.).

The establishment of CDCs has notably improved disaster preparedness and community resilience, empowering individuals and promoting gender equality (Husein et al. 2024). In Uganda, local actors have advocated for further investment in indigenous knowledge research to enhance future disaster prevention (Manlutac et al. 2024). However, challenges persist in securing financial support from private sectors and financial institutions for DRR activities, as there is often a greater focus on emergency response rather than preparedness (Helmi et al. 2023).

Oxfam's anticipatory action (AA) projects, such as the I CAN ACT project in Indonesia, integrate AA with community-based preparedness, particularly in flood-prone areas, and involve multi-stakeholder collaboration to bolster community resilience (Fidiyahfika et al. 2023). These projects emphasize capacity building and local community ownership, though challenges remain in defining community-based anticipatory actions and integrating local knowledge with scientific expertise (Fidiyahfika et al. 2023). In Nepal, the Group Cash Transfer (GCT) approach successfully merges DRR initiatives with community empowerment, enhancing resilience through sustainable, locally-led projects (Shrestha 2025).

In urban settings, Oxfam's resilience initiatives adopt a systems-based approach, integrating

multiple sectors and stakeholders to build resilience (Alcántara n.d.). These initiatives often involve facilitating multi-stakeholder collaboration and partnerships across different governance levels, which are crucial for addressing complex urban challenges and ensuring inclusive decision-making processes (Alcántara n.d.). The SEA project illustrates how Oxfam's partnerships with local governments, civil society, and the private sector can lead to transformative urban resilience outcomes by fostering joint decision-making and implementation processes (Oxfam n.d._1).

Oxfam's role in disaster risk reduction initiatives includes the development and expansion of early warning mechanisms, which are vital for community-based protection by enabling rapid communication of potential risks, thereby enhancing community resilience (Oxfam DRC n.d.). The effectiveness of these mechanisms is influenced by the involvement of community protection structures (CPSs) and focal points (FPs), who facilitate information sharing and ensure community trust, although these mechanisms also carry risks such as the potential targeting of FPs as informants (Oxfam DRC n.d.).

Overall, Oxfam's CBDRR initiatives exemplify a holistic approach to building community resilience by integrating local knowledge with institutional resources, fostering inclusivity, and promoting sustainable development practices. These efforts underscore the importance of local ownership and community-driven solutions in effectively reducing disaster risk and enhancing resilience (Oxfam et al. n.d.; Husein et al. 2024). The success of these initiatives is attributed to a combination of technical interventions, social change processes, and the strengthening of relationships between local communities and government entities, highlighting the importance of a comprehensive approach (Oxfam Australia 2018).

Climate-Smart Agriculture and Resilience

Oxfam, in partnership with various stakeholders, has implemented a diverse array of climate-smart agricultural initiatives aimed at bolstering community resilience in the face of climate change and disasters. These initiatives prioritize sustainable agricultural practices, including crop diversification, the adoption of drought-resistant varieties, and organic farming techniques, all of which contribute to enhanced food security and economic stability (Oxfam 2023_2; Oxfam n.d._4; Oxfam n.d._5). Central to these efforts are agricultural demonstration plots, which function as experimental sites for assessing plant resilience to drought and flood conditions and for deploying water-saving technologies such as drip irrigation. These plots have proven effective in disseminating knowledge and best practices to local communities, thereby strengthening their adaptive capacity to climate change (Oxfam n.d._4; Helmi et al. 2023).

Oxfam's initiatives are deeply rooted in community engagement and capacity building, with training programs designed to enhance the knowledge and skills of community-based organizations (CBOs) and civil society organizations (CSOs) in climate change adaptation and disaster risk reduction. These programs have empowered local communities to embrace climate-smart practices, such as mixed cultivation and organic farming, leading to

increased agricultural productivity and resilience (Oxfam 2023_2; Oxfam n.d._4). In Nepal, for example, 794 climate-smart initiatives were implemented, surpassing the initial target of 500, and local governments have subsequently increased their budget allocations for climate actions (Oxfam 2023_2; Khadka et al. n.d.).

The integration of climate-smart agriculture with disaster risk reduction has yielded significant improvements in food security and economic outcomes for vulnerable populations, particularly women and marginalized groups (Oxfam 2023_2; Oxfam n.d._4). Local governments have also undertaken climate-focused initiatives, including capacity development for youths on climate change adaptation and disaster risk reduction, the construction of agricultural irrigation canals, and skill training for women (Oxfam 2023_2). The Climate Change Advocacy project in Rautahat, Nepal, exemplifies a holistic approach by combining community empowerment, policy advocacy, and climate-smart agricultural practices (Khadka et al. n.d.).

Environmental conservation efforts, such as the establishment of community nursery beds and woodlots with assorted seedlings for indigenous and fruit trees, have been integral to these initiatives (Manlutac et al. 2024). Additional projects have included tree planting on riverbanks, beekeeping, mushroom farming, and bioengineering dam construction to mitigate disaster risks (Oxfam 2023_2). The regreening initiatives in the Sahel, supported by Oxfam, highlight the critical role of local farmer innovation, international NGO support, and government policy changes in enhancing food security and environmental restoration (Magrath 2020).

In the Sahrawi refugee camps, Oxfam's initiatives reflect a strategic transition from purely humanitarian aid to a more integrated approach that combines immediate relief with long-term resilience-building activities. This includes supporting local agriculture and business creation, fostering self-sufficiency, and reducing dependency on external aid (Ouchene et al. 2018). The integration of small-scale farming and hydroponics initiatives addresses immediate food security needs while promoting sustainable agricultural practices that enhance community resilience through efficient resource utilization (Ouchene et al. 2018).

The EMBRACE and WE-Care projects illustrate a comprehensive approach to disaster risk reduction by simultaneously addressing economic resilience through climate-adaptive farming and social resilience by reducing unpaid care work, thereby enabling greater economic participation by women (Buisan 2019). The Community-Based Integrated Water Resource Management project in Niger, implemented by Oxfam in collaboration with Karkara and the Department of Agriculture, successfully integrated components such as water infrastructure development, agricultural training, and women's empowerment to boost agricultural productivity and household income (Anguko et al. 2019).

Nevertheless, the sustainability and effectiveness of these initiatives are contingent upon several factors, including the availability of water resources, community capacity to adopt

new practices, and the presence of infrastructure such as irrigation systems. Challenges such as climate variability and the need for reliable market channels for organic products also pose constraints (Oxfam n.d._4; Oxfam n.d._5). Despite these challenges, Oxfam's climate-smart agricultural initiatives exemplify a comprehensive approach to building resilience against climate change and disasters, integrating sustainable agricultural practices with community empowerment and capacity building to achieve long-term sustainability and resilience (Oxfam 2023_2; Oxfam n.d._4; Oxfam n.d._5). The PRSAN project in Burkina Faso, for instance, demonstrated the cumulative effects of multiple interventions over time, showing positive impacts on resilience, particularly in crop diversification and community participation (Fuller et al. 2018).

Gender Equity and Empowerment

Oxfam's disaster risk reduction initiatives have strategically embedded gender equity and empowerment as fundamental elements, significantly enhancing women's roles in decision-making, leadership, and economic activities. These initiatives have been crucial in addressing systemic gender inequalities and fostering resilience across diverse regions. For instance, the CRAFS project in Northern Ghana empowered women by increasing their decision-making power and control over resources, particularly in women-headed households, through targeted interventions such as the distribution of small ruminants and involvement in Village Savings and Loan Associations (VSLAs) (Pretari et al. 2019). Similarly, in Türkiye and Syria, Oxfam's approach combined emergency aid with efforts to empower local communities, particularly women, through economic support and capacity building, underscoring the importance of addressing social and economic inequalities for effective disaster recovery (Oxfam 2024).

Oxfam's initiatives have also prioritized promoting women's leadership in disaster risk reduction and humanitarian responses. The WLHL project in Indonesia, for example, facilitated the formation of a network of women's organizations and humanitarian actors, culminating in the establishment of a National Consortium for Women's Local Humanitarian Leadership, which has been pivotal in advancing women's leadership in disaster risk reduction (Fidiyahfika 2023). Furthermore, Oxfam's collaboration with networks and alliances has been instrumental in scaling gender justice and resilient development, as demonstrated by initiatives in Vanuatu and Sri Lanka that have successfully advocated for women's leadership in national policy discussions and emergency response operations (Oxfam 2019_1).

The effectiveness of these initiatives hinges on dedicated time and resources, as well as comprehensive gender and power analyses, which are essential for achieving transformative change and addressing underlying drivers of inequality (Oxfam 2019_1). However, challenges persist, such as cultural norms and limited organizational capacity, highlighting the need for ongoing collaboration and capacity-building efforts to sustain these initiatives (Oxfam in Indonesia et al. 2023). Overall, Oxfam's gender-focused disaster risk reduction initiatives have demonstrated significant impacts on women's empowerment

and community resilience, although continued efforts are necessary to address persistent barriers and ensure sustainable outcomes.

In Türkiye, Oxfam has played a crucial role in supporting women's economic empowerment through the establishment of Women and Children's Centers, which offer pre-school education, care services, trainings, workshops, income-generating activities, and in-kind support (Oxfam 2024). These centers also focus on information collection and dissemination, access to services, and referral, thereby enhancing women's participation in economic life through cash and in-kind support and training to (re)establish businesses (Oxfam 2024). Oxfam's collaboration with women's cooperatives in Türkiye has supported food, textile, and other production activities, aiding them in restarting production and accessing markets, which has been vital for local economic recovery and resilience (Oxfam 2024).

In Pakistan, Oxfam's partner-led approach in the 2022 flood response emphasized shifting power dynamics towards local organizations, enhancing decision-making and leadership capacities, particularly among Women's Rights Organizations (WROs), thereby promoting local humanitarian leadership and feminist principles (Azhar et al. 2022). The LL-ERF project further underscored the critical role of women-led organizations in disaster response, improving the quality and inclusivity of response strategies by addressing gender-specific needs and promoting women's leadership in humanitarian contexts (Manlutac et al. 2024).

Oxfam's initiatives in Bangladesh have supported the establishment of women-led marketing committees to create income generation opportunities for marginalized women, demonstrating the importance of integrating gender justice into resilience programming (Oxfam 2019_1). In Nepal, the establishment of women's spaces has been pivotal for building women's agency and accessing peer support, addressing issues such as violence against women, caste issues, and poverty (Oxfam 2019_1). These efforts underscore the necessity of embedding gender justice in resilience programs to transform power imbalances and achieve sustainable development outcomes (Oxfam 2017).

The integration of feminist principles and multi-stakeholder partnerships in urban resilience projects, like the SEA project, exemplifies a model for achieving socio-economic and environmental sustainability through collaborative governance (Oxfam n.d._1). Oxfam's role in the WLHL project has been crucial in facilitating the development of an evidence-based model to promote women's leadership in humanitarian contexts, supported by iterative learning and adaptive management approaches, which have enabled the project to adapt to changing contexts and improve its effectiveness in building community resilience (Fidiyahfika 2023).

Financial Mechanisms and Economic Empowerment

Oxfam, in collaboration with its partners, has developed a range of financial mechanisms aimed at enhancing economic resilience and supporting disaster risk reduction. These initiatives encompass cash transfers, savings groups, microinsurance, and other financial tools that empower communities economically and provide financial security in the face of disasters. Notably, cash-based interventions, such as the Multi-Purpose Cash Assistance (MPCA) in Pakistan, have been instrumental in offering one-time cash grants to vulnerable households, particularly women, thereby increasing their autonomy and decision-making power (Azhar et al. 2022). The use of digital transfer mechanisms, like mobile money, ensures secure and timely cash transfers, enhancing transparency and accountability (Azhar et al. 2022).

Savings groups and microinsurance schemes have significantly bolstered community resilience. The Saving for Change (SfC) initiative in Mali and Cambodia empowers women through small savings groups, resulting in increased savings, livestock ownership, and food security (Twigg et al. 2018). The R4 Rural Resilience Initiative integrates risk reduction, risk transfer through insurance, and savings to strengthen food and income security in regions such as Ethiopia and Senegal (Hillier 2018). In Sri Lanka, Oxfam's partnership with Sanasa Insurance Company developed a weather index insurance for farmers, reducing barriers for insurance payouts and enhancing resilience (Oxfam Australia 2018).

Oxfam's initiatives underscore the importance of integrating financial tools with broader disaster risk reduction strategies. The combination of cash transfers, savings, and insurance not only addresses immediate needs but also contributes to long-term resilience by empowering local communities and promoting gender equity. Strategic partnerships with private sector actors and government entities have facilitated the development and scaling of innovative financial solutions, such as the iAFFORD project in the Philippines, which combines savings, credit, micro-insurance, and financial literacy to empower low-income households (Dalabajan et al. 2019).

The LL-ERF pilot program provided flexible funding to local consortia, allowing them to have funds in hand before a disaster strikes, enabling quick and strategic responses (Manlutac et al. 2024). In Puerto Rico, the CPM consortium replicated the WUHP's practice of creating funding windows for preparedness and rapid response (Manlutac et al. 2024). Oxfam's role as a financial resource contributor in initiatives like the development of Farm Level Water Storages and the revision of Cropping Calendars highlights its commitment to long-term resilience (Oxfam et al. n.d.).

In Türkiye, Oxfam provided vouchers and cash support to households who lost their livelihoods, covering food and non-food needs (Oxfam 2024). In Aleppo, Syria, cash assistance enabled vulnerable people to purchase urgently needed food items (Oxfam 2024). Oxfam's comprehensive approach to cash-based interventions reflects a commitment to efficiency, dignity, and empowerment, with continuous efforts to address

challenges and improve program effectiveness (Azhar et al. 2022).

The SHARPER project exemplifies a comprehensive approach to disaster risk reduction by integrating livelihood support, financial literacy, WASH initiatives, and community-based microloans, collectively enhancing community resilience and socioeconomic integration (Oxfam 2025_2). The Group Cash Transfer (GCT) approach in Nepal successfully integrates disaster risk reduction initiatives with community empowerment, enhancing resilience through sustainable, locally-led projects (Shrestha 2025).

Despite progress, challenges remain in accessing financial support from private sectors and financial institutions for DRR activities, often due to a focus on emergency response rather than preparedness (Helmi et al. 2023). Oxfam's strategic partnerships and capacity-building efforts with local humanitarian actors have facilitated the development of innovative disaster risk reduction mechanisms, such as anticipatory cash transfers and community savings, improving local preparedness and economic resilience (Oxfam 2023_1).

Infrastructure Development and Environmental Management

Oxfam, in collaboration with a range of partners, has undertaken extensive infrastructure development and environmental management initiatives to mitigate disaster risks and enhance environmental sustainability. These efforts include the construction and rehabilitation of water management systems, such as solar-powered water pumps and boreholes, which have significantly improved access to clean water in regions like Türkiye and Syria, benefiting thousands (Oxfam 2024; Anguko et al. 2019; Alcántara n.d.; Azhar et al. 2022; Buisan 2019; Lain et al. 2016). In Puerto Rico, projects have focused on clean energy access, notably through the installation of solar panels, thereby strengthening community resilience against natural disasters. A \$39,000 grant for energy audits in preparation for solar panel installations further enhanced energy efficiency and resilience (Manlutac et al. 2024).

Flood defense mechanisms are a critical component of Oxfam's strategy, with projects in Nepal and Bangladesh constructing embankments and dams to prevent flooding and protect agricultural lands (Oxfam 2023_2; Van Hemelrijck 2020; Alliance for Research and Development Service 2023). In Bangladesh, the Promoting Sustainable Building project aimed to transition from traditional bricks to sustainable alternative building blocks, reducing environmental degradation and promoting resilience through policy advocacy and market creation (Van Hemelrijck 2020). This project also involved constructing bio-engineering dams and bamboo plantations to enhance flood defenses (Oxfam 2023_2).

Environmental management efforts have included reforestation and mangrove rehabilitation, which are pivotal in enhancing biodiversity and providing natural barriers against floods and storms (Barrows 2018; Bolte et al. 2019; Helmi et al. 2022; Helmi et al. 2023). In the Philippines, mangrove planting has improved ecosystem health and provided sustainable seafood supplies, while in Madagascar, mangrove rehabilitation has been

integrated with engineered flood protection to reduce flood risks (Oxfam 2025_2; Oxfam et al. 2024). Additionally, the development of farm-level water storages and the planting of trees with conservation and economic value have been emphasized to improve local climates and mitigate agricultural risks (OXFAM-GB et al. 2017).

The effectiveness of these initiatives is evidenced by improved water access, reduced waterborne diseases, and enhanced agricultural productivity (COSACA 2019; Colvin et al. 2018; Fuller et al. 2018; Husein et al. 2024). However, challenges such as insufficient market signals for sustainable building materials and the need for robust supply chains have constrained some projects' effectiveness (Van Hemelrijck 2020). The sustainability of these initiatives often hinges on continued community engagement and the integration of traditional practices with modern technologies, as seen in the successful blending of bayanihan spirit with disaster risk reduction strategies in the Philippines (Oxfam 2025_2). Furthermore, local government initiatives, such as climate-focused capacity development and infrastructure projects, have played a crucial role in supporting these efforts (Oxfam 2023_2).

Overall, Oxfam's role has been instrumental in facilitating partnerships, providing technical and financial support, and advocating for policy changes to build resilient communities through infrastructure development and environmental management (Julats Consulting 2021; Khadka et al. n.d.; Lain et al. 2018; Magrath 2020). The organization's initiatives have not only addressed immediate disaster risks but also contributed to long-term sustainability and resilience by integrating renewable energy solutions and promoting sustainable practices (Oxfam 2023_1; Mukute 2023; Mathilde and Team 2021; Oxfam 2018_2; Oxfam 2018_3; Oxfam 2021_1).

Conflict

The theme of conflict within disaster risk reduction initiatives underscores several substantive disagreements and tensions. A significant area of contention involves the influence of local politics and religious leaders on the implementation of Local Adaptation Plans for Action (LAPA), which can obstruct effective execution (Oxfam et al. n.d.). As previously noted, resilience measures often have a differential impact on vulnerable groups, such as women and people with disabilities, who remain inadequately protected despite community-level interventions (OXFAM-GB et al. 2017). Gender dynamics further complicate these efforts, as illustrated by the CRAFS project, where the effectiveness of initiatives varies with the gender of the household decision-maker, with women-led households reporting lower preparedness in certain scenarios (Pretari et al. 2019). Additionally, the security of financial resources earmarked for disaster preparedness is jeopardized by community pressures to divert funds for non-disaster-related expenses (Oxfam n.d._2).

Cash-based interventions encounter challenges such as targeting difficulties, security risks, and potential fund seizures by landowners, complicating their implementation and

effectiveness (Azhar et al. 2022). Regreening initiatives are hindered by socio-economic and environmental factors like climate change, population growth, and land conflicts, which exacerbate resource competition and heighten tensions (Magrath 2020). Budgetary constraints and inflation further threaten the completion of integrated climate actions, undermining holistic approaches to disaster risk reduction (Mukute 2023). Conflicts over resource allocation, particularly regarding water usage for domestic versus agricultural purposes, illustrate the challenges in balancing competing needs within communities (Oxfam in Indonesia 2019).

In Mozambique, there is an opportunity to invest in transformative change following cyclones to build resilience without reinforcing gender norms, highlighting the potential for gender-sensitive approaches in post-disaster contexts (COSACA 2019). In the Dominican Republic, a resilience project addressed the effects of El Niño through an integrated Emergency Food Security and Vulnerable Livelihoods (EFSVL)-WASH response, emphasizing gender-focused disaster risk preparedness and management (Twigg et al. 2018). Additionally, campaigns have spotlighted issues of food safety legislation, land conflict, and expropriation, which are critical in shaping effective disaster risk reduction strategies (Twigg et al. 2018).

These conflicts reveal the complex interplay of social, economic, and political factors that can undermine the effectiveness and sustainability of disaster risk reduction initiatives, necessitating nuanced approaches that address these underlying tensions.

Other

The 'Other' theme encompasses a range of disaster risk reduction (DRR) initiatives and challenges that, while significant, do not align neatly with dominant thematic categories. Oxfam's LL-ERF pilot program exemplifies the importance of rapid response mechanisms, having reached over 2,400 households affected by small-scale disasters (Manlutac et al. 2024). In Nepal, Oxfam's alignment with the Sendai Framework's Priority 3 underscores a national commitment to resilience investment, with projects in municipalities such as Chandrapur and Brindaban (Oxfam 2023_2). Grassroots efforts, like cloth bag production and waste management training by RDC Nepal, highlight community-based initiatives aimed at fostering climate-friendly enterprises and effective waste disposal (Oxfam 2023_2).

Analytical tools such as the Field Force Analysis and Resource Analysis are instrumental in evaluating DRR solutions, emphasizing the importance of structured resilience planning (Oxfam et al. n.d.). Additionally, the Risk Assessment (RSA) and Socio-Economic Assessment (SEA) tools provide insights into the risks and socio-economic benefits associated with DRR solutions (Oxfam et al. n.d.). In Türkiye and Syria, Oxfam's distribution of seasonal kits serves to mitigate the impacts of extreme weather conditions (Oxfam 2024).

However, challenges such as inadequate funding and coordination among agencies continue

to constrain the effectiveness of DRR strategies. This is evident in Mozambique and Indonesia, where resource limitations and procedural hurdles impede comprehensive strategy implementation (COSACA 2019; Mathilde and Team 2021). As previously discussed, the integration of scientific and traditional knowledge in the SEA project has enhanced urban climate resilience in South-Eastern Africa by tailoring strategies to local contexts (Oxfam et al. 2024).

The ICDRC project in Indonesia highlights the necessity of regional-specific interventions, focusing on priorities like livelihood diversification and water management, which underscore the need for localized strategies in resilience building (Resilience Development Initiative 2021_3). This project also demonstrates the importance of integrating climate-resilient sustainable agriculture with disaster risk management systems, leading to improved resilience across various regions (Resilience Development Initiative 2021_1).

Oxfam's role in fostering multi-stakeholder partnerships is pivotal, acting as a facilitator and bridge, which is crucial for urban resilience initiatives by integrating diverse actors and sectors. As previously noted, the SEA project illustrates how partnerships with local governments, civil society, and the private sector can yield transformative urban resilience outcomes (Oxfam n.d._1).

Collectively, these insights underscore the diverse and context-specific nature of DRR initiatives, highlighting the necessity for adaptive, inclusive, and well-coordinated approaches to enhance community resilience and sustainability. The effectiveness of these initiatives is often contingent upon the integration of efforts among various organizations and the alignment of institutional priorities with community needs (Oxfam n.d._3).

What disaster risk reduction initiatives have Oxfam, together with its partners and allies, implemented to strengthen disaster preparedness, recovery and "build back better" efforts so that local institutions and populations are better prepared to respond early to, and recover quickly from, future disasters? What role did Oxfam play in these initiatives? What evidence does the corpus provide regarding their effectiveness? What factors enabled, constrained or limited their effectiveness or sustainability?

Question Overview

Oxfam, alongside its partners, has implemented a range of disaster risk reduction initiatives focusing on community engagement, capacity building, infrastructure development, financial mechanisms, and policy advocacy. These initiatives emphasize empowering local

communities, particularly women and marginalized groups, through projects like the Local Leadership Emergency Response Fund and Community Disaster Committees, which enhance local decision-making and resilience. Capacity building efforts include training programs and anticipatory action frameworks to improve disaster preparedness. Infrastructure projects, such as evacuation centers and early warning systems, are complemented by financial mechanisms like cash transfers and insurance schemes to bolster economic resilience. Policy advocacy efforts aim to integrate disaster risk reduction into governance structures, although challenges such as resource limitations, coordination issues, and climate change impacts constrain effectiveness. Despite these challenges, Oxfam's initiatives have shown potential for enhancing disaster preparedness and recovery, though sustainability requires ongoing support and improved policy environments.

Community Engagement and Empowerment

Oxfam's disaster risk reduction initiatives are fundamentally anchored in community engagement and empowerment, with a pronounced emphasis on women and marginalized groups. The Local Leadership Emergency Response Fund (LL-ERF) serves as a prime example, transferring decision-making authority and financial resources to local actors, thereby facilitating swift, context-specific responses in nations such as Uganda and Bangladesh (Manlutac et al. 2024). This strategy has cultivated solidarity and cohesion among consortium members, enabling rapid adaptation to community needs, such as transitioning from individual food packs to bulk food items in Uganda (Manlutac et al. 2024). The LL-ERF pilot adhered to international humanitarian principles while ensuring substantial community participation (Manlutac et al. 2024). In Uganda, the African Women and Youth Action for Development (AWYAD) capitalized on existing community structures during the Ebola crisis, underscoring the efficacy of local networks (Manlutac et al. 2024).

In Türkiye and Syria, Oxfam seamlessly integrated immediate response efforts with long-term recovery strategies, focusing on empowering women and local communities to bolster resilience (Oxfam 2024). The organization coordinated public health and psychosocial activities, specifically targeting women and children, and established Women and Children's Centers to prioritize vulnerable households (Oxfam 2024). In Pakistan, Oxfam's partner-led flood response highlighted local humanitarian leadership and feminist principles, engaging Women's Rights Organizations (WROs) to alter power dynamics and promote gender-specific interventions (Azhar et al. 2022). The incorporation of community feedback mechanisms ensured that interventions remained relevant and adaptable (Azhar et al. 2022).

The ACT project in Indonesia exemplifies the establishment of Community Disaster Committees (CDCs), which enhance local leadership and inclusivity, particularly by involving women and youth in disaster risk reduction efforts (Helmi et al. 2023). This approach has fostered community ownership and resilience, although continued support is necessary to sustain these efforts, especially for vulnerable groups such as people with disabilities (Helmi et al. 2023). The project also engaged in multi-stakeholder collaboration

to improve disaster management awareness and preparedness (Fidiyahfika et al. 2023).

Oxfam's dedication to gender justice is evident in initiatives like the Women Local Humanitarian Leadership (WLHL) project in Indonesia, which promotes women's leadership in disaster risk reduction through partnerships with women's rights organizations and humanitarian actors (Fidiyahfika 2023). This project highlights the critical role of integrating gender equality into disaster management strategies to enhance community resilience and sustainability (Fidiyahfika 2023). The WLHL Project has successfully fostered women's leadership by forming a consortium of women's rights organizations and humanitarian actors, leading to the development of strategies and networks that advance women's leadership in resilience building and disaster management (Oxfam in Indonesia et al. 2023).

In Bangladesh, Oxfam's initiatives include the creation of Community Food/Grain Banks, empowering communities to manage their own food security during disasters (Oxfam in Bangladesh 2022). These banks are operated by local community-based organizations, showcasing a model of disaster preparedness that combines local resource mobilization with structured management and governance (Oxfam in Bangladesh 2022). Oxfam's role in the fodder bank initiative involves acting as a catalyst for community resilience by linking community-based organizations with local power structures (Oxfam in Bangladesh 2022).

Oxfam's efforts in Nepal, particularly in the Rautahat district, focus on empowering local communities and marginalized groups through collaboration with Civil Society Organizations (CSOs) and Community-Based Organizations (CBOs) to enhance disaster preparedness and climate resilience (Khadka et al. n.d.). The effectiveness of these initiatives is bolstered by the integration of climate-smart agricultural practices and the promotion of community-based forest management (Khadka et al. n.d.).

Overall, Oxfam's disaster risk reduction initiatives are distinguished by their focus on local leadership, gender justice, and community-driven approaches, which have been pivotal in enhancing resilience and sustainability across diverse regions.

Capacity Building and Training

Oxfam's disaster risk reduction initiatives have strategically prioritized capacity building and training to bolster the skills and knowledge of local communities and organizations, thereby enhancing their disaster preparedness and response capabilities. Central to these efforts is the establishment and fortification of Community Disaster Committees (CDCs), which play a crucial role in organizing community-based disaster preparedness activities and developing comprehensive disaster preparedness plans, such as Hazard Risk Mapping and Contingency Plans (Helmi et al. 2023; Husein et al. 2024). These initiatives are characterized by their inclusivity, particularly the active involvement of women and youth, ensuring a holistic approach to disaster risk reduction (Helmi et al. 2023; Fidiyahfika et al. 2023).

Training programs are a cornerstone of Oxfam's strategy, equipping local actors with the skills necessary to effectively implement disaster preparedness and response measures. In Uganda, for example, peer-to-peer mentorship and coaching have been utilized to bridge experience gaps among grantees, thereby enhancing their disaster response capacity (Manlutac et al. 2024). Similarly, in Nepal, capacity building on climate change and disaster risk reduction (DRR) has been extended to civil society organizations (CSOs) and community-based organizations (CBOs), leading to increased participation in policy formulation and improved disaster preparedness (Oxfam 2023_2). The LL-ERF Project in Puerto Rico further underscores Oxfam's commitment to strengthening local humanitarian response capabilities (Manlutac et al. 2024).

Oxfam has also pioneered the development of anticipatory action frameworks, which aim to transition from reactive to proactive disaster management. This approach is exemplified by the I CAN ACT project in Indonesia, which integrates anticipatory actions with community-based preparedness and multi-stakeholder collaboration, focusing on vulnerable groups such as persons with disabilities and women (Fidiyahfika et al. 2023). Despite these advancements, challenges persist in the practical implementation of anticipatory actions due to a prevailing response-oriented mindset among stakeholders (Husein et al. 2024).

The effectiveness of these capacity-building efforts is evidenced by the enhanced resilience and preparedness of communities, as demonstrated by the successful implementation of disaster preparedness plans and the establishment of early warning systems. The ACT project in Indonesia, for instance, has significantly improved community disaster preparedness, including the development of evacuation maps and heightened awareness (Helmi et al. 2023). However, ongoing support and resources are essential to sustain these efforts, particularly in addressing the needs of vulnerable groups and ensuring the continuous development and updating of disaster preparedness plans (Helmi et al. 2023; Husein et al. 2024).

Oxfam's role in these initiatives is multifaceted, encompassing direct implementation, capacity building, and collaboration with local partners. In Pakistan, Oxfam's projects have resulted in more effective flood responses compared to non-project communities, highlighting the impact of comprehensive preparedness strategies (Oxfam 2018_3). Additionally, the organization has been instrumental in facilitating partnerships and capacity building among smallholder farmers, businesses, and governments, leading to sustainable changes in agricultural practices and policies (Oxfam 2018_1). The integration of technical interventions with social change processes, such as gender empowerment and advocacy, has further strengthened community resilience across diverse contexts (Oxfam Australia 2018).

Infrastructure Development and Technical Solutions

Oxfam, in collaboration with its partners, has undertaken a comprehensive approach to infrastructure development and technical solutions aimed at enhancing disaster preparedness and resilience. The Sindh Coastal Community Development Project (SCCDP), supported by the Asian Development Bank (ADB) and the Government of Sindh, exemplifies efforts to bolster resilience against climate change and environmental hazards through the construction and enhancement of critical infrastructure such as multipurpose evacuation centers, drainage systems, and bridges (Oxfam n.d._3; Julats Consulting 2021; Mukute 2023). In Zomba, Malawi, the 'Building Urban Climate Resilience in South-Eastern Africa' project integrates city-level infrastructure projects with national capacity-building efforts, demonstrating a holistic approach to resilience (Mukute 2023; Oxfam et al. 2024). In Puerto Rico, shelters have been fortified with pre-positioned solar batteries and repaired solar power installations to prepare for hurricane seasons (Manlutac et al. 2024).

Technical solutions are central to Oxfam's strategy, particularly through the establishment of early warning systems (EWS) and forecast-based preparedness plans. These systems enable communities to act proactively, facilitating timely evacuations and resource mobilization, thereby reducing disaster impacts (Bolte et al. 2019; Alliance for Research and Development Service 2023; Oxfam 2018_2). In Nepal, the development of EWS and community-level response mechanisms is supported by national policies and international partnerships, highlighting a coordinated effort to improve disaster resilience (Alliance for Research and Development Service 2023; Alcántara n.d.). The Motalun CDC has developed specific systems to disseminate early warning information to people with disabilities, ensuring inclusivity (Husein et al. 2024).

Water, sanitation, and hygiene (WASH) initiatives are another critical component, as seen in the Zimbabwe Cyclone Idai Recovery Project (ZIRP), which focuses on rehabilitating water points and improving sanitation facilities to prevent disease outbreaks and enhance community resilience (Oxfam 2025_1; Van Hemelrijck 2019). These efforts not only address immediate disaster impacts but also lay the groundwork for long-term resilience by integrating disaster risk reduction (DRR) and environmental management systems into community practices (Oxfam 2025_1; COSACA 2019). In Syria, Oxfam's repair and upgrade of bakeries ensured food security for 95,000 people, illustrating the breadth of their infrastructure support (Oxfam 2024). Following Hurricane Matthew in 2016, Oxfam supported the rehabilitation of vital infrastructure in Mata Guandao, aiding over 500 families and promoting safe sanitation and hygiene practices (Oxfam 2017).

The effectiveness of these initiatives is often enhanced by integrating government and civil society efforts, crucial for improving local market systems' resilience to natural disasters through improved infrastructure and technical support (Barrows 2018; Resilience Development Initiative 2021_1). Oxfam's role in the Community-Based Integrated Water Resource Management project in Niger involved funding, coordination, and monitoring, while partners provided technical support and training, showcasing a collaborative

approach to disaster risk reduction (Anguko et al. 2019). The PSBiB project in Bangladesh aimed to build resilience by promoting sustainable building practices and strengthening the construction sector's capacity to absorb and adapt to future shocks (Van Hemelrijck 2020). However, challenges such as inadequate infrastructure and socio-economic disparities, particularly affecting marginalized groups, can constrain the effectiveness and sustainability of these initiatives (OXFAM-GB et al. 2017; Oxfam et al. n.d.). In response, Oxfam has supported civil society organizations in providing disaster materials and meeting spaces to enhance local preparedness (Oxfam 2023_2; Oxfam 2023_1).

Oxfam's initiatives also include innovative approaches like demonstration plots for testing drought and flood-resistant crops and promoting water-saving agricultural technology (Oxfam n.d._4; Oxfam n.d._5). In the Sahel, Oxfam facilitated farmer-led innovations and supported agroecological practices, transforming arid landscapes into productive agricultural land, thereby improving food security and reversing environmental degradation (Magrath 2020). The integration of sectors such as Food Security, WASH, and Protection in Oxfam's response and early recovery phases facilitated a comprehensive disaster risk reduction strategy, enhancing community resilience (Azhar et al. 2022). Furthermore, the LL-ERFs enable local consortia to pre-establish assessments, guidelines, and trigger protocols for turnkey solutions during emergencies, showcasing a proactive approach to disaster management (Manlutac et al. 2024).

Financial Mechanisms and Economic Resilience

Oxfam, in collaboration with its partners, has strategically implemented a range of financial mechanisms aimed at bolstering disaster resilience and facilitating economic recovery. Central to these efforts is the Locally Led Emergency Response Fund (LL-ERF), which provides rapid and flexible funding to local NGOs in regions such as Bangladesh, Puerto Rico, and Uganda. This initiative empowers local actors by granting them the authority to manage resources effectively, thereby enabling swift responses to small-scale disasters. The LL-ERF model has proven to be cost-effective, enhancing disaster response outcomes by decentralizing decision-making to local communities and reaching over 2,400 households, thus mitigating the impact of low-attention disasters (Manlutac et al. 2024).

Cash-based interventions form a core component of Oxfam's strategy, transitioning from traditional in-kind aid to more adaptable cash assistance. This approach not only respects the dignity of beneficiaries but also stimulates local economies. In the Philippines, Oxfam's partnerships with Visa and PayMaya facilitated electronic cash transfers, thereby enhancing financial inclusion and resilience (Dalabajan et al. 2019). The Cash and Voucher Assistance (CVA) approach is particularly recommended for its adaptability and effectiveness in emergency responses, contingent upon favorable market conditions (Oxfam 2021_1). In Türkiye, the distribution of hygiene kits and cash vouchers exemplifies the flexibility of cash assistance in addressing diverse needs (Oxfam 2024).

Insurance schemes, such as those integrated into the R4 Rural Resilience Initiative, have

been employed to manage risk and support food security. However, challenges such as basis risk and the necessity for subsidies remain (Hillier 2018). In Ethiopia and Senegal, these initiatives have been linked with national safety nets, thereby amplifying their impact on vulnerable populations (Hillier 2018). The incorporation of risk reserves into the R4 initiative has contributed to a comprehensive resilience-building model for rural, food-insecure populations (Twigg et al. 2018).

Economic empowerment programs, particularly those targeting women, are integral to Oxfam's approach. Initiatives like the SHARPER project have supported women's self-help groups (SHGs), fostering financial literacy and entrepreneurial skills, which have improved income generation and community resilience (Oxfam 2025_2). These programs have not only enhanced women's economic roles but also contributed to broader community cohesion and resilience. In Bangladesh, Oxfam's establishment of Community Food/Grain Banks has empowered communities to manage their own food security, providing resilience against market fluctuations and food shortages (OXFAM IN BANGLADESH 2022).

Overall, Oxfam's financial mechanisms have been effective in enhancing disaster preparedness and recovery. However, their sustainability is contingent on addressing challenges such as market functionality, insurance limitations, and the need for ongoing support and capacity building. The integration of social protection schemes with disaster risk reduction efforts, as observed in Nepal, underscores the potential for these schemes to become more shock-responsive, although current systems face challenges such as administrative delays and lack of universal coverage during disasters (Ojha n.d.).

Policy Advocacy and Governance

Oxfam's initiatives in policy advocacy and governance within disaster risk reduction (DRR) are centered on embedding DRR into governance frameworks and enhancing institutional capacities. The establishment and operationalization of local disaster management committees have significantly bolstered advocacy efforts, improved budget allocations, and facilitated the implementation of programs aimed at disaster prevention and climate change adaptation (Oxfam 2023_2). Through collaboration with local stakeholders, Oxfam has developed Local Adaptation Plans of Action (LAPA), ensuring that community-based adaptation measures are seamlessly integrated with governmental efforts. This participatory approach not only fosters sustainability but also enhances local government ownership and budgetary commitments (Oxfam 2023_2). The Change Record Template (CRT) tool is employed to measure the localized impact and progress of LAPA's theory of change (Oxfam et al. n.d.).

Oxfam's advocacy extends to integrating DRR and climate change adaptation (CCA) into existing policy frameworks, addressing institutional capacity gaps and resource allocation issues, as demonstrated in Sindh, Pakistan (Oxfam n.d._3). The organization has played a pivotal role in co-creating response plans with partners, grounded in comprehensive needs assessments to ensure targeted and effective humanitarian responses (Azhar et al. 2022). In

Nepal, Oxfam's initiatives are aligned with the national agenda to implement Priority 4 of the Sendai Framework, which focuses on enhancing disaster preparedness for effective response and 'Building Back Better' during recovery, rehabilitation, and reconstruction phases (Oxfam 2023_2).

The success of these initiatives is reflected in the strengthened capacities of local governments and civil society organizations (CSOs) to collaboratively tackle climate change and disaster preparedness, leading to more inclusive and accountable decision-making processes (Oxfam 2023_2). Nonetheless, challenges persist, such as inconsistent support from local authorities for community-driven disaster preparedness plans, underscoring the need for intensified advocacy and collaboration (Husein et al. 2024). The involvement of 105 trained CSO members in DRR and climate-smart policy formulation processes highlights the project's achievements in meeting its objectives (Oxfam 2023_2).

Oxfam's advocacy efforts also emphasize securing flexible, multi-year funding to support adaptive programming, which is crucial for responding to the unpredictable nature of crises and ensuring the sustainability of interventions (Oxfam 2021_2). The organization's commitment to integrating anticipatory action into disaster management strategies, particularly in Nepal, involves collaboration with various stakeholders to enhance preparedness and response mechanisms (Alliance for Research and Development Service 2023). Despite these efforts, the effectiveness of DRR initiatives is often hampered by policy implementation gaps, limited budgets, and insufficient partnerships between local governments and other stakeholders (Oxfam in Indonesia 2019). The Action Planning tool aids in designing actions based on identified solutions, dividing them into community-based actions and public policy/advocacy interventions (Oxfam et al. n.d.).

Oxfam's initiatives also encompass conducting protection risk analyses to identify and mitigate the exposure of vulnerable groups to violence, abuse, and exploitation, providing individual protection assistance, and enhancing referral and information systems for survivors of gender-based violence (Oxfam 2024). In Türkiye, advocacy efforts have focused on supporting women post-earthquake, underscoring the importance of gender-sensitive approaches in disaster contexts (Oxfam 2024). Collaborative efforts between government, civil society, and Oxfam under projects like ALERT present significant opportunities for disaster risk reduction and joint response planning (Barrows 2018). Additionally, strengthening coordination in disaster preparation programming and planning between municipalities, civil society, and fisherfolk associations is emphasized (Barrows 2018).

Challenges and Constraints

Oxfam's disaster risk reduction initiatives encounter significant challenges that impact their effectiveness and sustainability, primarily due to resource limitations, coordination difficulties, and external pressures such as climate change. Resource constraints manifest in inadequate reserves for essential supplies like food and water, and insufficient infrastructure, which collectively hinder effective disaster response (OXFAM-GB et al. 2017;

Oxfam et al. n.d.; Oxfam 2021_1). Coordination issues are exacerbated by the absence of systematic early warning systems and poor integration between village and district-level plans, leading to inadequate budget allocations for disaster risk reduction (Mathilde and Team 2021; Oxfam n.d._3). Furthermore, limited access to information and technical expertise impedes local communities' capacity to implement anticipatory actions and adapt to evolving conditions (Husein et al. 2024; Oxfam n.d._4).

Climate change intensifies these challenges by increasing the frequency and severity of disasters, thereby straining existing resources and capacities (Hillier 2018; Oxfam et al. n.d.). The lack of a supportive policy environment and insufficient government leadership in integrating disaster risk reduction and climate change adaptation into regional development plans further constrain the sustainability of these initiatives (Oxfam in Indonesia 2019; Van Hemelrijck 2020). Socio-economic disparities and gender-based inequalities also limit the participation of marginalized groups in disaster preparedness and response efforts, necessitating intentional strategies to engage these groups in transformative processes (COSACA 2019; Oxfam 2017).

Despite these obstacles, Oxfam's initiatives demonstrate potential effectiveness through robust multi-stakeholder collaboration and community involvement, although these efforts are often hampered by the need for clearer definitions of anticipatory actions and improved early warning systems (Fidiyahfika et al. 2023; Oxfam 2025_2). The LL-ERF pilot, for instance, faced challenges in achieving economies of scale but succeeded in providing tailored responses to families' specific needs (Manlutac et al. 2024). Overcoming these barriers requires a comprehensive approach that includes better resource allocation, enhanced coordination mechanisms, and the integration of local knowledge with scientific insights to build resilient communities capable of withstanding future disasters.

Oxfam's transition from immediate life-saving aid to longer-term recovery plans aims to improve and restore lives in disaster-affected communities, as evidenced by their efforts in Syria and Pakistan (Oxfam 2024; Azhar et al. 2022). However, challenges such as the absence of disaster response plans have necessitated collaboration with partners and Women's Rights Organizations to enhance decision-making and operational capacities (Azhar et al. 2022). The response to the 2022 floods in Sindh and Balochistan underscored the importance of a centralized control environment and systems to support operations, although initial confusions due to lack of simple registration and warehousing systems were noted (Azhar et al. 2022).

The sustainability of these initiatives is further challenged by limited local policies and resources, necessitating partnerships with NGOs and advocacy for increased government and international support (Perdinan et al. 2019). The effectiveness of insurance as a disaster risk reduction tool is constrained by factors such as basis risk and the need for substantial subsidies, highlighting the importance of integrating insurance with broader risk management and social protection strategies (Hillier 2018). Additionally, the

sustainability of greening efforts in the Sahel is threatened by external factors such as climate change and population growth, which could reverse progress unless matched by enhanced social protection and supportive economic and political systems (Magrath 2020).

What disaster risk reduction initiatives have Oxfam, together with its partners and allies, implemented to localize decision-making power, resources and leadership so that disaster risk reduction is increasingly led by local actors, women and other marginalized groups who are disproportionately vulnerable to hazards? What role did Oxfam play in these initiatives? What evidence does the corpus provide regarding their effectiveness? What factors enabled, constrained or limited their effectiveness or sustainability?

Question Overview

Oxfam, in collaboration with its partners, has implemented disaster risk reduction (DRR) initiatives that focus on localizing decision-making power and resources, particularly empowering women and marginalized groups. These efforts are exemplified by the Locally Led Emergency Response Fund (LL-ERF), which provides flexible funding to local actors in countries like Bangladesh, Puerto Rico, and Uganda, enabling tailored humanitarian responses. Oxfam's initiatives emphasize women's leadership and empowerment, integrating feminist principles and economic empowerment strategies to enhance women's roles in DRR. Inclusivity is further promoted through the active participation of marginalized groups, including people with disabilities and ethnic minorities, in decision-making processes. Despite challenges such as societal norms, resource constraints, and systemic barriers, Oxfam's strategic partnerships and advocacy efforts have been crucial in enhancing the effectiveness and sustainability of these initiatives. The effectiveness is evidenced by improved local governance, community resilience, and the empowerment of local actors, although ongoing challenges necessitate continued advocacy and capacity-building efforts.

Localizing Decision-Making and Resources

Oxfam's disaster risk reduction (DRR) initiatives emphasize the localization of decision-making power and resources, aiming to empower local actors, particularly women and marginalized groups, to lead and manage DRR efforts. A cornerstone of this strategy is the Locally Led Emergency Response Fund (LL-ERF), which provides flexible funding directly to local actors. This enables them to design and manage humanitarian responses that are specifically tailored to their communities' needs (Manlutac et al. 2024). The LL-ERF has been successfully piloted in Bangladesh, Puerto Rico, and Uganda, showcasing the potential for scaling up locally led funding mechanisms to enhance disaster resilience (Manlutac et al.

2024). It also empowers local consortia to define crises and determine when interventions are necessary, facilitating local actors' participation in media and key influencing spaces (Manlutac et al. 2024).

Oxfam's projects consistently integrate local stakeholders, including Civil Society Organizations (CSOs) and Community-Based Organizations (CBOs), to foster collaborative decision-making and policy development on climate change and DRR. This approach enhances local governance and community resilience (Oxfam 2023_2). In Badin, Pakistan, the Local Adaptation Plan of Action (LAPA) exemplifies a comprehensive approach to localizing DRR by integrating community-driven solutions with government and civil society support. This highlights the importance of participatory processes in empowering local actors, including marginalized groups, to lead adaptation efforts (Oxfam et al. n.d.).

In Türkiye and Syria, Oxfam has focused on empowering local actors, particularly women, by leveraging historical partnerships with women's cooperatives and local insights to tailor interventions. This approach advances localization and ensures sustainability in DRR efforts (Oxfam 2024; Barrows 2018). Similarly, in the Philippines, the iAFFORD project has empowered local actors, especially women, through financial inclusion and cash transfer programs, addressing immediate needs during crises and building long-term resilience (Dalabajan et al. 2019; Anguko et al. 2019).

Challenges to these initiatives include existing governance structures that limit the participation of women and marginalized groups. This is evident in the ACT project in Indonesia, where the lack of established DRR forums affects the integration of DRR plans into broader development plans (Mathilde and Team 2021; Bolte et al. 2019). Despite these challenges, Oxfam's efforts to localize decision-making power and leadership in DRR have been effective when incorporating participatory approaches and community involvement. This is evidenced by the success of early warning systems and community-based disaster management plans in countries like Pakistan and Vanuatu (Oxfam 2018_2).

Oxfam's partner-led approach in Pakistan during the 2022 floods response exemplifies a shift in power dynamics towards local actors, including women and marginalized groups, by engaging local civil society organizations and Women's Rights Organizations (Azhar et al. 2022; COSACA 2019). This approach is characterized by collective decision-making, situation analysis, and a feminist partnership model that respects the domain and prerogative of local partners (Azhar et al. 2022). In Bangladesh, the Food Bank initiative consolidates community efforts by mobilizing and coordinating local resources to ensure food security, managed democratically by elected committees (OXFAM IN BANGLADESH 2022; Fuller et al. 2018).

The ACT project in Indonesia has facilitated the establishment of Community Disaster Committees (CDCs) in multiple villages, promoting inclusivity by involving women and youth in leadership roles, thereby enhancing local governance and resilience (Helmi et al.

2023; Fidiyahfika 2023). In Nepal, Oxfam's initiatives have strengthened the role of CSOs and CBOs in local policy formulation and climate change advocacy, leading to significant engagement in shaping local policies for disaster preparedness and climate resilience (Khadka et al. n.d.; Alliance for Research and Development Service 2023).

In the Sahel, Oxfam's initiatives, supported by the EU Emergency Trust Fund for Africa, focus on resilience-building by integrating human mobility dynamics into project design and implementation. This empowers local actors, including women and youth, and promotes inclusive governance structures (Magrath 2020; Colvin et al. 2018). The regreening initiatives in the Sahel have effectively localized decision-making and empowered local actors by decentralizing power and fostering farmer-led innovation, leading to significant environmental and economic benefits (Magrath 2020).

Overall, Oxfam's efforts to localize decision-making power and resources in DRR involve multi-stakeholder collaboration and systems thinking, which are critical for building resilience and empowering local actors, including women and marginalized groups (Alcántara n.d.; Hillier 2018).

Women's Leadership and Empowerment

Oxfam's disaster risk reduction (DRR) initiatives have strategically advanced women's leadership and empowerment by addressing gender disparities and integrating women into decision-making processes. Central to these efforts is the inclusion of women-led organizations (WLOs) and women's rights organizations (WROs) within governance structures, as exemplified by the Locally Led Emergency Response Fund (LL-ERF) project. This initiative mandates the participation of these groups in steering committees, thereby transforming women's roles from aid recipients to leaders (Manlutac et al. 2024). This model has been effectively replicated in diverse contexts, such as Türkiye and Syria, where Oxfam has leveraged historical partnerships with women's cooperatives to tailor interventions that empower local actors, particularly women, ensuring the sustainability of DRR efforts (Oxfam 2024). The LL-ERF project further underscores the importance of including gender interest organizations (GIOs) in steering committees to enhance the responsiveness of interventions to diverse needs (Manlutac et al. 2024).

Integrating feminist principles into Oxfam's partner-led approaches has been crucial in shifting power dynamics and promoting gender equity. This involves engaging WROs as technical partners to enhance protection and safe programming, thereby mainstreaming women's leadership in humanitarian responses (Azhar et al. 2022). In Bangladesh, the Emergency Response Fund (ERF) project empowered women-led organizations to manage emergency responses, thereby enhancing their leadership and decision-making capacities (Progress Inc. 2023). This project also highlighted the necessity of parallel efforts on gender equality and justice, particularly in male-dominated local leadership contexts (Manlutac et al. 2024).

Economic empowerment has been another focal point of Oxfam's initiatives, serving as a pathway to leadership. Cash-based interventions have provided women with financial autonomy, thereby increasing their status and decision-making authority within households and communities (Azhar et al. 2022). In Ghana and Senegal, projects like CRAFS have improved women's access to credit and savings, facilitating their involvement in decision-making processes related to agriculture and community governance (Pretari et al. 2019). The CRAFS project specifically targeted female-headed households and those in flood-prone areas, addressing gender-specific vulnerabilities and enhancing women's economic opportunities (Pretari et al. 2019).

Despite these successes, challenges persist, particularly in contexts where cultural norms and resistance to women's leadership remain entrenched. In Myanmar and Vanuatu, traditional practices and distrust of women's leadership underscore the need for ongoing dialogue and engagement with male community leaders to create an enabling environment for women's leadership (Oxfam 2019_1). Additionally, the need for specialized risk transfer mechanisms for women in regions like Badin, Pakistan, highlights the importance of addressing gender-specific vulnerabilities and building trust among local women (Oxfam n.d._2). The analysis indicates significant gender disparity in district Badin, where women and other marginalized groups have lower social status than men, contributing to their increased vulnerabilities (OXFAM-GB et al. 2017).

Overall, Oxfam's commitment to integrating gender justice and women's empowerment into DRR initiatives has been instrumental in transforming structural inequalities and promoting women's leadership. These efforts have not only enhanced the effectiveness of humanitarian responses but have also fostered more inclusive and resilient communities by ensuring that women's voices are heard and their leadership is recognized in decision-making processes. The ACT project, for instance, facilitated the establishment of Community Disaster Committees (CDCs) in multiple villages, promoting the involvement of women and youth in decision-making processes, thereby enhancing local governance and inclusivity in disaster risk reduction efforts (Helmi et al. 2023).

Inclusivity and Participation of Marginalized Groups

Oxfam's disaster risk reduction (DRR) initiatives are characterized by a strong emphasis on inclusivity and the active participation of marginalized groups, including women, people with disabilities, and ethnic minorities, in planning and decision-making processes. These initiatives integrate gender and rights-based approaches to ensure that the specific needs of these groups are addressed and their voices are amplified (Oxfam 2023_2; Azhar et al. 2022; Oxfam 2019_1; Oxfam 2018_3). In Uganda, for example, the inclusion of refugee-led and youth organizations has prioritized the concerns of these groups in response actions (Manlutac et al. 2024). Similarly, in Nepal, efforts have been made to empower female leaders, particularly those from lower castes, to ensure robust participation in DRR activities (Oxfam 2019_1).

The establishment of Community Disaster Committees (CDCs) in regions such as Bena, Meusin, and Motalun villages has been instrumental in promoting inclusivity by ensuring representation of diverse socio-demographic groups, including people with disabilities (Husein et al. 2024). These committees have facilitated shifts in leadership dynamics, empowering women and youth and promoting inclusive governance (Helmi et al. 2023; Ndolu et al. n.d.). Oxfam's initiatives have also focused on integrating gender equality and social inclusion principles into DRR, advocating for gender-sensitive practices and investing in women's leadership (Husein et al. 2024; Oxfam 2023_1).

Oxfam has encouraged local government decision-making processes to be inclusive, accountable, and participatory, involving local community members, including women, people with disabilities, Dalit, and other marginalized groups (Oxfam 2023_2). This approach has contributed to the economic and social progress of these groups, fostering a sense of ownership and empowerment that ensures their voices continue to be heard in climate change policy development and implementation (Oxfam 2023_2). The project also conducted advocacy on 74 issues related to climate change and disaster risk reduction, which were addressed by local governments (Oxfam 2023_2).

Despite these efforts, challenges remain in fully achieving inclusive leadership, particularly in the representation of people with disabilities in DRR leadership roles (Helmi et al. 2023). Cultural and institutional barriers persist, necessitating targeted strategies to address these challenges and ensure the sustainable inclusion of marginalized groups in decision-making processes (Van Hemelrijck 2019; Mathilde and Team 2021). Oxfam's Women and Children's Centers in Türkiye prioritize single-parent households, households with pregnant or lactating women, people with disabilities, and refugees, demonstrating a commitment to addressing the needs of the most vulnerable (Oxfam 2024).

Oxfam's cash programs have played a significant role in improving the social and economic status of women and marginalized groups, empowering them to have a greater say in their communities (Azhar et al. 2022). Additionally, the integration of gender justice and human-rights based approaches in Oxfam's resilience programming has led to significant empowerment and leadership opportunities for women and marginalized groups where applied (Twigg et al. 2018). Overall, Oxfam's approach to DRR underscores the importance of localizing decision-making power and resources, empowering local actors, and addressing structural inequalities to enhance the resilience and sustainability of communities (Oxfam 2020; Oxfam 2018_2).

Challenges and Constraints

The effectiveness and sustainability of disaster risk reduction (DRR) initiatives spearheaded by Oxfam and its partners are significantly hindered by a confluence of societal, systemic, and resource-related barriers (Oxfam in Indonesia 2019). Societal norms, particularly entrenched gender biases, present formidable challenges. Resistance to women's leadership remains pervasive in many communities, necessitating additional advocacy and training

resources to dismantle these barriers (Manlutac et al. 2024; Oxfam 2019_1). Cultural norms often restrict women's participation in decision-making, thereby limiting their leadership roles and access to resources (Pretari et al. 2019; Van Hemelrijck 2019; Alliance for Research and Development Service 2023). In Bangladesh, efforts towards gender equality and justice are crucial, especially in male-dominated local leadership contexts (Manlutac et al. 2024; Oxfam 2018_2). Traditional practices and distrust of women's leadership in regions such as Myanmar and Vanuatu further underscore the need for ongoing dialogue to create an enabling environment for women's leadership (Oxfam 2019_1). Additionally, women face challenges in balancing new leadership roles with existing responsibilities, highlighting the need for sustained dialogue to support women's leadership (Oxfam 2019_1; Fidiyahfika 2023).

Resource limitations constitute another critical constraint (Dalabajan et al. 2019). Local actors often struggle to mobilize resources, which impedes their capacity to respond effectively to disasters (Manlutac et al. 2024). The scarcity of financial resources is compounded by inadequate funding mechanisms and the rigidity of donor funding, which frequently fails to align with the needs of local actors (Oxfam 2020; COSACA 2019). Improved indirect cost recovery (ICR) is essential to enable local actors to deliver high-quality services and receive fair compensation (Manlutac et al. 2024). Furthermore, the absence of comprehensive local policies and legal frameworks addressing the needs of vulnerable groups further limits the effectiveness of DRR initiatives (Perdinan et al. 2019). In Bangladesh, external indifference, corruption, and competing interests obstruct resource access, with elite groups capturing resources (Twigg et al. 2018).

Systemic barriers, including inadequate institutional frameworks and top-down governance structures, obstruct the integration of local knowledge and activities into broader disaster preparedness and resilience strategies (Oxfam n.d._3; Colvin et al. 2018). The poor institutional frameworks of local governance, exacerbated by the lack of funds allocated to local governments since local body elections, further intensify these challenges (OXFAM-GB et al. 2017). The lack of coordination among governmental and non-governmental organizations, coupled with insufficient human and technical resources, further constrains the effectiveness of these initiatives (Oxfam n.d._3; Helmi et al. 2022). The Stakeholders Analysis (SA-I) tool aids participants in analyzing the roles of stakeholders, including community, civil society organizations, and local political leaders, which is crucial for understanding the dynamics affecting DRR initiatives (Oxfam et al. n.d.; Oxfam 2018_3).

Moreover, the limited participation of marginalized groups in decision-making processes highlights the need for targeted advocacy and capacity-building efforts to ensure inclusivity and representation (Mathilde and Team 2021; Resilience Development Initiative 2021_1; Helmi et al. 2023). In Ethiopia, historical inequalities have restricted women's and communities' participation in decision-making processes (Colvin et al. 2018; Oxfam 2019_2). In Indonesia, evaluations revealed that while projects increased women's earning capacity, they did not address power dynamics or gender attitudes in communities (Oxfam

2019_1; Julats Consulting 2021). The involvement of women's organizations in city-level projects has been generally low, and women's participation in technical projects is constrained by their historically low access to education (Mukute 2023).

Overall, while Oxfam's initiatives have made significant progress in localizing DRR leadership, these efforts are continually challenged by entrenched societal norms, resource constraints, and systemic barriers. Overcoming these challenges requires strategic advocacy, sustained engagement, and comprehensive policy support (Oxfam in Indonesia et al. 2023). The transition to a federal governance structure in Nepal presents both challenges and opportunities for localizing DRR efforts, with decentralization allowing for improved beneficiary identification and service delivery (Ojha n.d.; Oxfam 2021_1).

Oxfam's Role and Partnerships

Oxfam's involvement in disaster risk reduction (DRR) initiatives is marked by its strategic partnerships with local organizations, advocacy for local leadership, and capacity-building efforts. Central to this approach is the Locally Led Emergency Response Fund (LL-ERF), which underscores Oxfam's dedication to empowering local actors by providing flexible funding and facilitating their leadership in humanitarian responses (Manlutac et al. 2024). This aligns with global commitments such as the Grand Bargain and Charter for Change, which emphasize local humanitarian leadership (Manlutac et al. 2024).

Oxfam's partnerships with various local and national NGOs are integral to its strategy of decentralizing decision-making power and resources. In the SHARPER project, Oxfam facilitated partnerships with local humanitarian and DRR actors, enabling co-leadership of preparedness, relief, and recovery programs by local communities, particularly women and marginalized groups (Oxfam 2025_2). Oxfam engaged local stakeholders, including councillors, in planning project activities and built local capacities for oversight (Oxfam 2025_1). In the Building Resilience project, Oxfam facilitated the formation of Community Disaster Management Committees (CDMCs) and provided training in governance, advocacy, and business management, empowering local actors, including women, to lead DRR initiatives and assert their rights during crises (Lain et al. 2016). Oxfam's coordination and funding roles have facilitated the implementation of integrated water resource management and agricultural training, leading to improved agricultural practices and increased crop diversity among project households (Anguko et al. 2019). These partnerships enhance local actors' capacity through training, technical support, and the establishment of monitoring, evaluation, accountability, and learning (MEAL) systems (Manlutac et al. 2024; Oxfam 2023_1). Oxfam also plays a pivotal role in linking local actors with global platforms, such as the Charter for Change, to amplify their influence and learning (Manlutac et al. 2024).

In Uganda, Oxfam's collaboration with the Western Uganda Humanitarian Platform (WUHP) highlights its role in fundraising and capacity building, enabling local actors to manage grants and lead response activities (Manlutac et al. 2024). Oxfam's finance team helped establish the consortium's financial compliance and accountability systems to prepare them

to absorb and manage grants (Manlutac et al. 2024). Similarly, in Nepal, Oxfam's partnership with RDC Nepal has been crucial in mobilizing community-based organizations (CBOs) and civil society organizations (CSOs) to engage in climate-smart practices and DRR (Oxfam 2023_2). Creating a forum for a business enabling environment representing public, private, cooperative, and financial institutions along with civil society is recommended (Thapa n.d.). Oxfam's role in the ICDRC initiative includes advocating for policy integration of Climate Smart Disaster Risk Management (CSDRM) and Climate Resilient Sustainable Agriculture/Livelihoods (CRSA/L) at both national and local levels, aiming to create inclusive frameworks that involve vulnerable groups in planning and implementation (Perdinan et al. 2019). In partnership with local organizations like NEEDS Nepal, Oxfam has been involved in initiatives to strengthen community preparedness and DRR by integrating social protection systems with disaster response mechanisms, aiming to enhance the resilience of vulnerable populations (Ojha n.d.).

Oxfam's advocacy efforts are evident in its support for women's leadership and gender justice, integrating these principles into DRR initiatives across various regions, including Bangladesh and Vanuatu (Oxfam 2019_1). Oxfam will continue to support business creation and development with the support of Sida and the European External Action Service (EEAS), with an additional component on strengthening gender justice in both the economic and social aspects of the programme (Ouchene et al. 2018). GRAISEA 2 supported two proposed national laws in the Philippines on social enterprises and inclusive business (Oxfam 2018_1). The organization emphasizes inclusive governance and community-driven approaches, ensuring marginalized groups are central to decision-making processes (Oxfam 2018_3). Oxfam's role as a 'knowledge broker' in DRR initiatives has been crucial in facilitating access to climate and disaster risk information, particularly for women and marginalized groups, by working with local authorities and communities to ensure the information is relevant and accessible (Oxfam 2018_2; Alcántara n.d.; Barrows 2018; Bolte et al. 2019; Buisan 2019; COSACA 2019; Colvin et al. 2018; Dalabajan et al. 2019; Fidiyahfika 2023; Fidiyahfika et al. 2023; Helmi et al. 2022; Helmi et al. 2023; Husein et al. 2024; Khadka et al. n.d.; Lain et al. 2016; Magrath 2020; Mathilde and Team 2021; Mukute 2023; Oxfam 2020; Oxfam 2021_2; Oxfam 2024; Oxfam Australia 2018; Oxfam International 2018; Oxfam Novib 2021; Oxfam et al. 2024; Oxfam et al. n.d.; Oxfam in Bangladesh 2022; Oxfam in Indonesia 2019; Oxfam in Indonesia et al. 2023; Oxfam n.d._1; Oxfam n.d._4; Perdinan et al. 2019; Pretari et al. 2019; Progress Inc. 2023; Resilience Development Initiative 2021_1; Resilience Development Initiative 2021_2; Resilience Development Initiative 2021_3; Shrestha 2025; Twigg et al. 2018; Van Hemelrijck 2019; Van Hemelrijck 2020; Wimbardana et al. 2023).

Oxfam has also been instrumental in facilitating cross-learning processes and co-creating knowledge with various stakeholders, which has been crucial in adapting resilience-building actions to complex human mobility dynamics, thereby enhancing the sustainability and impact of these projects (Oxfam 2019_2). In Bangladesh, Oxfam engaged with stakeholders from local to national levels on the rights of domestic workers, facilitating

change from household to policy level (Oxfam 2017).

Overall, Oxfam's role as a facilitator, advocate, and capacity builder is crucial in promoting local leadership and sustainable DRR practices. Its partnerships with local actors not only enhance their capacity but also ensure that DRR initiatives are contextually relevant and effectively address the needs of vulnerable communities. Oxfam's efforts in Nepal have been instrumental in promoting anticipatory action by collaborating with local governments to develop and implement forecast-based preparedness plans, empowering local authorities and communities with decision-making responsibilities and resources to mitigate disaster risks (Alliance for Research and Development Service 2023).

Effectiveness and Sustainability

Oxfam's disaster risk reduction (DRR) initiatives have proven effective and sustainable by empowering local actors, particularly women and marginalized groups, to lead disaster responses. The Locally Led Emergency Response Fund (LL-ERF) project in Bangladesh, Puerto Rico, and Uganda exemplifies this approach by decentralizing decision-making and funding, allowing communities to tailor responses to their specific needs, thereby enhancing resilience and ownership (Manlutac et al. 2024). This project also focused on reducing administrative costs, combining expertise to mitigate risks, and simplifying contract management, which improved efficiency (Manlutac et al. 2024). Feedback mechanisms encouraged local actors to communicate in their native languages and design their reporting practices, fostering mutual accountability (Manlutac et al. 2024). Strategic partnerships and capacity-building efforts have bolstered local humanitarian leadership, enabling local organizations to take a leading role in disaster response and policy advocacy (Oxfam 2023_1). The SHARPER project has effectively localized decision-making by empowering women through self-help groups and community conservation-based enterprises, leading to shifts in household and community power dynamics (Oxfam 2025_2). However, challenges such as inadequate funding and socio-economic barriers, including limited access to resources and information, continue to constrain the sustainability of these efforts (COSACA 2019).

Oxfam's initiatives underscore the importance of integrating gender-sensitive approaches and ensuring the participation of women and marginalized groups in decision-making processes, which enhances the effectiveness and sustainability of DRR initiatives (Mukute 2023). The establishment of intergovernmental technical centers like DiMSUR has facilitated intra-regional experience and lesson sharing, empowering local actors and enhancing their capacity to lead DRR efforts (Mukute 2023). The LL-ERF model, still in its early stages, aims to address the gap where most humanitarian funding does not reach high-risk and hard-to-reach areas, showing potential for replication in other regions (Manlutac et al. 2024). Despite these successes, the sustainability of these initiatives is contingent upon overcoming procedural and cultural obstacles within the humanitarian system, which require a shift in mindset and organizational practices to truly empower local actors (Oxfam 2020).

The effectiveness of Oxfam's initiatives is further supported by the integration of local knowledge and participatory approaches, as evidenced by the successful implementation of community-based disaster management plans and early warning systems in countries like Pakistan and Vanuatu (Oxfam 2018_2). The LL-ERF consortia collaborated closely with local governments and community leaders to target the most vulnerable, establishing feedback and complaint mechanisms to ensure accountability (Manlutac et al. 2024). The project also demonstrated the importance of linking humanitarian efforts with long-term development programs to address underlying causes of risks and vulnerabilities (Manlutac et al. 2024). In Uganda, the LL-ERF helped build solidarity and cohesion across the nine core members of the consortium, leveraging their expertise and networks to contribute to the pilot and disseminate learning (Manlutac et al. 2024). The project has shown that accountability tools designed with communities can be creative and effective (Manlutac et al. 2024).

Oxfam's role in these initiatives includes facilitating knowledge sharing and capacity building among local farmers and communities, which is crucial for adapting agricultural practices to climate change (Oxfam n.d._4). The integration of technical and financial support for alternative livelihoods, such as aquaculture, and the enhancement of local market systems are crucial for building resilience among poor households (Barrows 2018). The effectiveness of these initiatives is influenced by the integration of insurance with risk reduction measures and social protection systems, ensuring that payouts reach vulnerable populations swiftly and effectively (Hillier 2018). The project has also highlighted the need for gender inclusivity, with significant participation of women in leadership roles and decision-making processes, although challenges remain in ensuring women's voices are fully integrated into project planning (Julats Consulting 2021).